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INSIDE



Pakistan claims it killed 22 radicals in air attacks

ISLAMABAD
Pakistan on Thursday said it killed at least 22 militants in air strikes in Afghanistan as part of a campaign to eliminate their hideouts. Afghanistan's Taliban regime, meanwhile, said that Pakistani strikes killed nine Afghan civilians, including women and children, and injured 11 others. » PAGE 14



HC strikes down 34% quota for BC in A.P. local polls

VIJAYAWADA
The Andhra Pradesh High Court on Thursday set aside Government Orders through which the government provided 34% reservation to the Backward Classes in Panchayat Raj Institutions and 33.33% quota in the Urban Local Bodies. » PAGE 3

West Bengal govt. obstructing work as MP: Mahua

NEW DELHI
The Supreme Court on Thursday sought responses from the Union government and the State of West Bengal to a petition filed by Krishnanagar MP Mahua Moitra alleging a concerted effort by the State authorities and the police, using goons and mobs, to impede her from accessing her constituency. » PAGE 4

Roadside birth in U.P: four doctors found negligent

BHADOHI
Four doctors and a nurse have been found guilty of serious negligence in connection with a pregnant woman allegedly being denied admission to a district hospital in Uttar Pradesh, forcing her to deliver on the roadside, officials said on Thursday. » PAGE 6

Manufacturing PMI touches 55.1 in September

NEW DELHI
Manufacturing activity rose to a seven-month high of 55.1 in September, according to a private sector survey. However, activity in the second quarter was the weakest since the COVID-19-impacted Q2 of 2021-22. » PAGE 12

UAE probes ‘terrorist’ link to flight incident

Israeli PM credits the Indian flydubai pilot for averting a tragedy after co-pilot stabbed him

Netanyahu said he expected the UAE to take the lead in the investigation and Israel will join later

Trump says there might be an ‘Iran link’ to the attack; White House is working on it, he adds

Agence France-Presse
DUBAI

The UAE announced on Thursday it was probing a possible “terrorist” link to an apparent attack by a pilot on board a flight from Dubai to Tel Aviv that saw passengers reroute the plane to stop it from crashing.

The dramatic events on Wednesday ended with passengers being given a hero’s welcome by Israel Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu back home in Israel as they arrived from Saudi Arabia, where the plane made an emergency landing earlier.

Mr. Netanyahu credited the flydubai pilot, Indian national Smit Machchhar, as well as passengers with averting catastrophe, after a co-pilot allegedly stabbed him and tried to crash the plane. Passengers described rushing to the cockpit after the plane sud-

denly plummeted, losing around 17,000 feet of altitude in the span of a minute, according to the Flightradar24 website.

Israeli officials have called the incident “an attempted terrorist attack”. Mr. Netanyahu said that the co-pilot had undergone “Islamist radical indoctrination... The attacker, he calls out to the aircrew, ‘Kill me, kill me,’ making it “clear he was suicidal”.

U.S. President Donald Trump said there might be an “Iran link” to the co-pilot.

The UAE’s chief prosecutor said an investigation had been launched into the incident, including the possibility of “terrorist activity or intent”.

Mr. Netanyahu said he expected the UAE to take the lead in the investigation, but that Israel would join. “He’ll be, I assume, moved very quickly to Du-



Survivor’s account: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu interacts with Yaniv Hayun, a passenger who was aboard the flydubai airliner, on Thursday. REUTERS

bai,” Mr. Netanyahu said about the alleged attacker, who was being questioned in Saudi Arabia.

Israel’s far-right National Security Minister, Itamar Ben Gvir, called it a “jihadist” attack, while Defence Minister Israel Katz also described the incident as

“an attempted jihadist terrorist attack”.

Mr. Trump was asked by presspersons at the White House whether he had been briefed about any links between the pilot behind the attack and Tehran. He responded, “I would say the answer,

based on what I’m hearing, is yes, but we’re working on it right now,” Mr. Trump said. He did not offer details. Asked if the U.S. would retaliate against Tehran if it was behind the attack, Mr. Trump said, “Oh they’ll be hit, very hard, don’t worry.”

Machchhar’s kin and friends await news of recovery

MUMBAI
Pride over Captain Smit Machchhar’s bravery aboard flydubai flight FZ1073 was tempered by an anxious wait for news of his recovery on Thursday, as childhood friends, neighbours and residents in Mumbai prayed for his safe return home. The pilot was seriously injured during the attack inside the cockpit of the Dubai-Tel Aviv flight on Wednesday. » PAGE 4

and apparently tried to crash the plane with everyone on board,” Mr. Netanyahu said in a video message.

He later hailed the wounded pilot, Mr. Machchhar, “for his extraordinary bravery”, saying he prevented a “catastrophic mid-air disaster”.

Indian embassy in Saudi Arabia said Mr. Machchhar was being treated at a hospital in the country.

Passenger Miryam Shira Ohayon described the plane as being “pretty much out of control” as the incident unfolded over Jordan.

“The co-pilot tried to murder the pilot and basically carry out a suicide attack on the plane,” she told presspersons by speakerphone at Ben Gurion Airport.

(With inputs from AP)

RELATED REPORTS ON
» PAGE 4

Enduring lessons



Remembering the Mahatma: Children take part in a charkha workshop organised by the Art, Cultural, and Educational Enlight Foundation ahead of Gandhi Jayanti at Ravindra Kala Kshethra in Bengaluru on Thursday. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

Block licence renewal for unpaid traffic fines, says SC

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has directed the States and Union Territories to block a range of online and vehicle-related services for motorists with outstanding traffic fines, including registration renewals, fitness and pollution-under-control certificates, ownership transfers, and driving licence renewals.

The court was informed that e-challans worth about ₹49,194.05 crore remained outstanding across the country, while ₹26,175.05 crore had been recovered so far.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 6

Shivakumar protests; EC orders probe into Form 7 fraud charge

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

The Election Commission (EC) on Thursday ordered a probe into the filing of Form 7s in bulk seeking deletions of names from final electoral rolls following a five-hour protest by Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar and his Cabinet colleagues.

Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Karnataka, V. Anbu Kumar, directed all Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) to take action against applicants who “knowingly” make false statements or declarations while filing claims or objections in Forms 6, 6A, 7, and 8.

Mr. Shivakumar withdrew the protest after the announcement.

Earlier in the day, he alleged that “pre-filled” Form 7s were filed in bulk across the State by the Opposition BJP and Janata Dal (Secular) workers, targeting Muslims, and members of the Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes, claiming they had either “shifted” or were “absent”.

‘False or forged’

He said many Form 7s were either false or forged.

In at least two instances, in Belagavi and Vijayapura, BJP workers who filed Form 7s in bulk withdrew those after being warned of punitive action if the claims were found to be false. In a written declaration, they said they had made a mistake.

The Karnataka Police registered five FIRs on Thursday over bulk Form 7s invoking the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, and not the Representation of the Peo-



D.K. Shivakumar staging a protest outside the CEO’s office in Bengaluru. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

ple Act, 1951, as only EC officials can lodge complaints under the latter. Mr. Shivakumar demanded that poll body must take suo motu action and lodge criminal complaints.

Mr. Anbu Kumar noted that there were instances of bulk filing of Form 7 applications before the EROs and that some of the forms were “alleged to be not genuine” and directed the EROs to take action under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, “against applicants found to have knowingly made false statements or declarations.”

“However, such action shall be preceded by an inquiry under Rule 20 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960,” he said.

Earlier in the day, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, took to social media citing *The Hindu’s* report on how Form-7 applications were being filed against Muslim names in Belagavi and other districts in bulk, and said it was yet another proof of “vote theft”.

PARLEY
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RELATED REPORTS ON
» PAGE 5

INBRIEF



Patient’s death not linked to my convoy, says Assam CM

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday said stopping the ambulance to let his convoy pass is not related to the patient’s death, and asserted that no inconvenience should be caused to people due to his or any Minister’s movement. The patient, Rasuraj Chakraborty of Sribhumi, was being shifted to the Silchar Medical College Hospital on Wednesday when the ambulance carrying him was stopped to let the Chief Minister’s convoy pass. He died in the hospital on Thursday morning. “The patient was suffering from a critical liver ailment and his death is not related to the brief halt,” Mr. Sarma said.

MMRDA starts digital system for project-affected families

The Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA) on Thursday launched ‘e-Punarvasan’, a digital rehabilitation and resettlement (R&R) system aimed at verifying project-affected families through Aadhaar and preventing ineligible beneficiaries from receiving homes. MMRDA Commissioner Sanjay Mukherjee issued possession letters to 94 eligible slum dwellers from Bandra’s Garib Nagar. The system integrates surveys, electricity bill and Aadhaar-based OVSE verification, computerised allotment, possession letters and digital monitoring. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said it would reduce improve transparency.

Cong. accuses U.P. govt. of creating ‘one district, one mafia’ model in State

Day after Supreme Court rap for U.P. Police, State’s AICC in-charge says comments reflect ‘anarchy prevailing under BJP rule’; SP chief Akhilesh Yadav says force working like ruling party workers

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday attacked the BJP government in Uttar Pradesh over the law and order situation, alleging that Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath had created a “one district, one mafia” model in the State with criminals enjoying political protection. The party alleged that Dalits and the vulnerable were bearing the brunt of what it described as a “nexus between criminals and those in power”.

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday also alleged that Uttar Pradesh Police was “working like a BJP worker”, citing the Supreme Court’s recent criticism, and called for ousting the ruling party to resolve the “crisis”. “The Supreme Court and the High Court have repeatedly said what we have been saying - the police cannot be trusted. Police are working like BJP workers,” Mr. Yadav said at a press conference in Lucknow.



U.P. witnessed on an average nine murders, 10 attempted murder cases every day, said AICC in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam. FILE PHOTO

rence in Lucknow.

His remarks came a day after the Supreme Court sharply criticised Uttar Pradesh Police during a hearing in a molestation case from Bulandshahr. The Bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva said, “It is better if we ask CBI to step in and take over all U.P. Police investigations. We might as well disband U.P. Police. This nonsense has to stop at some point.”

All India Congress Committee (AICC) in-charge of Uttar Pradesh Rajendra Pal Gautam claimed that the State witnessed, on an av-

erage, nine murders, 10 attempts to murder, nine rapes, 33 kidnappings and around 235 violent crimes every day.

Mr. Gautam also referred to recent observations by the Supreme Court and the Allahabad High Court on the functioning of the Uttar Pradesh police, claiming that they reflected the “anarchy prevailing under BJP rule” in the State.

Congress leader Abhay Dubey alleged that the Adityanath government had provided such protection to criminals that they had begun “harassing the public openly”. “The State re-

cords the highest number of acid attacks on daughters,” he said.

Mr. Dubey alleged that the Chief Minister had established a “one district, one mafia” model and that criminals belonging to a particular caste were being shielded.

“Today, the people of Uttar Pradesh are asking Yogi Adityanath: how long will this reign of terror continue?” he said.

Congress Lok Sabha member Imran Masood alleged that “only hatred is being spread” in Uttar Pradesh. “The talk here is not about uniting, but only about dividing,” he said.

New U.P. chief

Mr. Gautam also answered about the ongoing speculation about a change in the leadership of the Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee and said the decision rested with the party’s central leadership. “This is a matter for the leadership; it does not fall within my ambit,” he said.

(With inputs from PTI)

Volunteers detained in Haryana ahead of CM’s visit, alleges CJP

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leader Sudhir Sangwan alleged that several party volunteers were detained or placed under house arrest across Haryana ahead of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini’s visit to Hisar on Thursday, amid protests over the Common Eligibility Test (CET).

According to Mr. Sangwan, the CJP had submitted memoranda supporting the protesting students to Deputy Commissioners in 14 districts on September 28. He alleged that the police subsequently identified party volunteers associated with the programme. “In Haryana, the police are illegally detaining CJP colleagues because they had submitted a memorandum to DC Jhajjar the day before yesterday... in support of the CET students Hisar protest,” Mr. Sangwan posted on X on Wednesday night.

Mr. Sangwan claimed that the volunteers were picked up without prior notice or legal proceedings.

Mr. Sangwan said that the three volunteers detained in Jhajjar were released after noon on Thursday after being



Mr. Saini assured the protesters that their demands would be looked into. FILE PHOTO

picked up around 8.30 p.m. on Wednesday.

Chandramohan, a CJP member, told *The Hindu* that he was detained from his home in Jhajjar district around 7.30 p.m. on Wednesday. He alleged that the personnel did not show him any document or explain the reason for his detention.

Repeated calls and text messages to Additional DGP (Law and Order) Sanjay Singh went unanswered.

CM’s assurance

On Thursday, Mr. Saini met the protesters and assured them that their demands, including annual conduct of the CET, permanent local employment, an end to contractual recruitment, etc. would be looked into. Subsequently, the protesters decided to postpone the stir till December 6.

Soon after SIR process, Chief Electoral Officer of Odisha opts for voluntary retirement

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Odisha’s Chief Electoral Officer R.S. Gopalan has applied for voluntary retirement from service after the process of special intensive revision (SIR) got over in the State. The 1968-born and 2001-batch IAS officer applied for VRS on Wednesday. Odisha’s final electoral roll was published on September 21. “I applied for VRS on personal grounds, and it has nothing to do with the SIR process. I have already completed 25 years of service. I became eligible for a full pension on September 2, 2025,” Mr. Gopalan told *The Hindu*.

‘A smoother exercise’

With one and a half years left for his retirement, Mr. Gopalan oversaw the SIR process in Odisha, which, according to him, was



Applied for VRS on personal grounds, it has nothing to do with the SIR process, said R.S. Gopalan (centre). FILE PHOTO

smoother than in other States. “We heard 58 lakh anomalies and disposed of them. Had I been under any pressure because of the SIR, I would have tendered my resignation then. The SIR process was completed in Odisha without any unpleasant incident,” he said.

The Opposition Biju Janata Dal, however, had submitted several memoranda alleging the exclusion of voters from the electoral roll. “The timing of his VRS

raises suspicions, particularly at a time when Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar is under tremendous pressure over the ‘Vote Chori’ allegations. It appears that his decision to take VRS was driven by pressure from the Chief Election Commissioner or the State government,” said Odisha Pradesh Congress Committee president Bhakta Charan Das, who described Mr. Gopalan as “absolutely honest”.

Cracks widen within ruling UDF as Congress leaders speak out against Keralam govt.’s style of functioning

NEWS ANALYSIS

S. Anandan
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Signs of an imminent implosion within Keralam’s ruling United Democratic Front (UDF), particularly within its lead party the Congress, were apparent on Thursday when UDF convener Adoor Prakash openly expressed his displeasure over UDF chairman and Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan’s “unilateral” style of functioning.

Mr. Prakash’s criticism was not an isolated expression of resentment. He was echoing the sentiments of several senior Congress leaders, some of whom shared similar concerns in off-the-record conversations with *The Hindu*.

Mr. Prakash’s unusual outburst conveys the impression that matters have come to a head. Demand has been rife within the



UDF chairman and Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan

Congress for a reorganisation of the State party unit, given that many office-bearers, including State unit chief Sunny Joseph, also hold ministerial portfolios, leaving them with little time for organisational work and little command over the government.

A senior Congress leader and member of the Political Affairs Committee said in exasperation that the high command has left the party in the lurch. “Our concerns have been shared with Deepa Dasmunsi, the All India Congress Committee (AICC) general se-

cretary in charge of Kerala. The person who must act is K.C. Venugopal, the AICC general secretary in charge of organisation, but he too is biding his time after losing the chief ministerial race despite having greater support among party legislators,” the leader said.

‘Returning favour’

The reported appointment of M.K. Muneer, a leader of the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), a constituent of the UDF, as chairman of the Administrative Reforms Commission, a post with Cabinet rank, has also irked some, who have termed it “needless” and “politically damaging”.

“The IUML had vociferously backed Mr. Satheesan’s claim for chief ministerial rank and, it appears, he’s returning the favour,” a Congress leader said.

After securing a wafer-thin majority in the 2011 Assembly poll, the then Oommen Chandy-led UDF

government was forced to do a tightrope walk, conceding to the IUML’s controversial demand for a fifth Cabinet Minister in 2012. “But the Congress is in a far better position now and there is no real compulsion to give the post of Administrative Reforms Commission chairman to the IUML on a platter,” another leader said.

The Bharatiya Janata Party has not taken kindly to the move, with senior leaders K. Surendran and MLA V. Muraliedharan viewing it as the IUML prevailing over Mr. Satheesan.

Some Congress leaders said All India Forward Bloc leader G. Devarajan, reportedly appointed the government’s special representative in Delhi with Cabinet rank, lacked the clout or bargaining power to be of any help to the State. A Delhi-based leader would have fit the bill, a party leader said. “Come to think of it, do we really

need these posts any longer, if not for accommodating favourites?” he added.

A senior leader, known for his “virtuous” stances, said Mr. Satheesan would be doing a great disservice to the party if he chooses to “follow in the footsteps of his predecessor [former Chief Minister and CPI(M) leader Pinarayi Vijayan]” in public compartment, handling of the media, and on issues of transparency.

“He has now given the weekly Cabinet briefing a miss. When questions were asked about the sponsors of his chartered flight [to flood-hit Malappuram district recently], he could have cleared the air. The public ought to know who is footing the Chief Minister’s airfare,” he said.

With the Congress high command stuck in a wait-and-watch mode, more party leaders are likely to go public with their criticism of the UDF government in the coming days.

Drug menace takes centre stage in BJP’s Punjab poll campaign as it cuts across caste, religion and age

NEWS ANALYSIS

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

The drug menace in Punjab has stayed at the centre stage of political and social attention for more than a decade and because it cuts across caste, religion and age, it appears to have become a major political issue for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

With an eye on the Assembly election, which is due in early 2027, the BJP had launched its ‘Nasha Mukht Punjab Yatra’ campaign on September 18, under which party leaders and workers undertook four separate marches from different locations to



Farmers and BJP workers take part in a tractor march during the ‘Nasha Mukht Punjab Yatra’ near Ghanaur, in Patiala. FILE PHOTO

cover all 117 Assembly constituencies of Punjab. The campaign culminated in Jalandhar on September 30, where Union Home Minister Amit Shah urged voters to give the BJP a chance to form the next government and promised to make Punjab free of the drug menace by December 31, 2029.

The saffron party, which has historically struggled to make inroads in Punjab, is aggressively pushing its campaign around the drug menace issue to get a foothold in the border State.

Despite repeated promises to eradicate it, successive governments have failed to address the drug

menace. Before the 2017 Assembly election, then Congress leader Captain Amarinder Singh had, while taking an oath of *Gutka Sahib* (a small book with sacred verses from *Guru Granth Sahib*), promised the people of the State to stamp out the menace of drugs within four weeks of assuming power. The Congress ruled from 2017 to 2022, yet the drug problem remained. The now-ruling Aam Aadmi Party made a similar promise in 2022, saying it would end the drug menace within four months of forming the government. Four and a half years later, the problem continues to plague the State. The Shiromani Akali Dal and the BJP have also faced public wrath over

the drug menace when, as alliance partners, they ruled the State from 2007 to 2017. Their opponents accused them of letting the illegal drug trade flourish under their regime.

Pointing to substance abuse, health and social surveys have indicated that Punjab could have between 1 lakh and 2.7 lakh people who were dependent on opioids. Findings from the study in 2017, which was carried out over the preceding two years, titled ‘Epidemiology of Substance Use and Dependence in the State of Punjab’, released by the Post-graduate Institute of Medical Education and Research, revealed that about one in every 87 persons was dependent on drugs.

MLC poll: JD(U)’s Anant Singh escorts Oppn. candidate to file nomination, calls for his victory

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Janata Dal-United (JD-U) MLA and *bahubali* (strongman) Anant Singh on Thursday travelled in an open jeep to accompany the Opposition Jan Suraj Party’s (JSP) candidate, Anuj Singh, as the latter filed his nomination papers for the forthcoming State Legislative Council election from the Patna graduates’ constituency. Mr. Anant Singh declared that he would ensure Mr. Anuj Singh’s victory “at any cost”. The JD(U) is the ruling National Democratic Alliance’s (NDA) ally in Bihar.

Mr. Anant Singh, who represents the Mokama con-

stituency in the Bihar Assembly, has been defying the candidature of party spokesperson Neeraj Kumar to the seat, claiming he would “ensure Neeraj Kumar’s defeat at any cost as he has sought to defeat me four times during Assembly elections”.

Eight State Legislative Council seats in Bihar – four graduates’ and four teachers’ constituencies – go to the polls on October 23, 2026.

“I do not know what the party line is as, in this (MLC) election, there is no need to contest on a party’s symbol. The fact remains that he (Neeraj Kumar) has opposed me four times in Assembly elections. So I

will oppose him in the same way this time and ensure his defeat, come what may,” Mr. Anant Singh told media persons while accompanying Mr. Anuj Singh.

Bitter rivals

Mr. Neeraj Kumar has been elected from the Patna graduates’ constituency thrice. He was bitter that Mr. Anant Singh had contested several times as an Independent candidate from Mokama since 2015, snapping ties with the JD (U), sources said, while the party fielded Mr. Neeraj Kumar against Mr. Anant Singh from the seat the latter had won by comfortable margins.



HC clears way for bypolls in 2 more T.N. constituencies

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court has cleared the decks for the conduct of byelections to two more constituencies by rejecting an election petition with respect to the Perundurai constituency and striking off a plea to declare the runner-up in the Ambasamudram constituency as the returned candidate.

Justice P.B. Balaji on Thursday refused to reject an election petition filed by a voter challenging the victory of Esakki Subaya from the Ambasamudram Assembly constituency, but struck off the relief sought by the election petitioner to declare the runner-up, V.P. Durai of the Congress, as the winner.

The judge dismissed an application filed by Mr. Subaya – who had won as an AIADMK candidate, but later resigned from his post and joined the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam – to reject the election petition preferred by S. Kanthimathinathan.

“In the present case, I am conscious of the fact that despite being the returned candidate, the first respondent (Mr. Subaya) has resigned from his MLA post and the electorate remains unrepresented as on date. But, for the prayer sought for invoking Section 84 of the R.P. Act, read with Section 101 of R.P. Act, the Election Commission would be clearly well within its right to conduct a fresh election,” Justice Balaji said.

A.P. HC strikes down 34% BC quota in local body elections

Court says the reservation exceeds the 50% threshold laid down by the Supreme Court; it further directs State government and State Election Commission to begin poll process within six weeks

V. Raghavendra
VIJAYAWADA

A Division Bench of the Andhra Pradesh High Court, comprising Chief Justice Lissa Gill and Justice Challa Gunaranjan, on Thursday set aside Government Orders 105 and 1065 through which the government provided 34% reservation to the Backward Classes (BCs) in Panchayat Raj Institutions (PRIs) and 33.33% quota in the Urban Local Bodies (ULBs).

The court said that they exceeded the 50% threshold laid down by the Supreme Court.

While striking down the impugned G.O.s, the court



The High Court gives liberty to the State to revisit the issue and determine the percentage of reservation for BCs. FILE PHOTO

gave liberty to the government to revisit the issue and determine the percentage of reservation for BCs keeping in view the apex court judgment in *Janhit Abhiyan vs Union of India* after completing the exercise of data collection in compliance with the judg-

ment in *Vikas Kishanrao Gawali vs State of Maharashtra*. The judges have expressed the opinion that the empirical data collected by the State through unified family survey cannot form the basis of declaration for reservation for the BCs. In the same vein, the

court directed the State government and the State Election Commission (SEC) to expeditiously commence the process of holding elections to the PRI and ULBs preferably not later than six weeks from October 1.

Continued operation of electoral rolls in existence on the qualifying date cannot be affected by the special intensive revision (SIR) and it cannot be the reason for postponement of the elections, the judges said.

On delimitation of Municipalities and Municipal Corporations, they said the Census Act of 1948 or Census Rules, 1990 do not prohibit the State from undertaking the process.

Kodagu poll booth sees bulk Form 7 filing against Muslims

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

In a similar trend seen across multiple Assembly constituencies in Karnataka, where pre-filled Form 7 applications were filed in bulk seeking deletion of Muslim voters' names, at least 50 applications were filed against Muslim names at a single polling station at the Government Higher Primary School at Bydagotta in Kodagu district on September 23 alone.

The objectors said the forms had been sent from the “party office”.

All the applications cited “absent” as the reason for deletion. Data accessed by *The Hindu* shows that at least 50 Form 7 applications were filed by objec-

tors named Rajni, B.N. Basavaraju, Lokesh, Savitha Malali, and A.C. Nagaraj. However, officials in Somwarpet where the polling station is, said they had not received any of these applications.

When contacted by *The Hindu*, Mr. Basavaraju and Ms. Rajni said they had filed 10 applications each, claiming they had “doubts” that the voters had “duplicate” entries.

Asked why “absent” had been cited as the reason when they had claimed the voters had duplicate entries, the objectors said they had followed instructions from the party office in Somwarpet. However, it is to be noted that the forms were already printed with the voters' names.

Veeramani, two associates booked under Goondas Act

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

Greater Chennai Police Commissioner A. Amalraj has ordered the detention of Gem Granites founder R. Veeramani, 84, and his associates, Shanthi, 60, and her husband Mahendra Simhan, 63, under the Goondas Act for allegedly engaging in repeated criminal activities and disturbing public order.

The Immoral Trafficking Prevention Unit arrested Veeramani on August 29, on charges of sexually assaulting minor girls, and the other two accused for abetting him.

They were remanded in judicial custody and lodged at the Central Prison in Puzhal. Subsequently, the police registered two more cases against Veeramani for driving minor girls to suicide.

Meanwhile, the police said they were probing the financial transactions made by the businessman.

The police said that so far, four cases have been registered under various provisions of the law based on complaints, including those lodged by the girls and their relatives.

The police said they continued to receive complaints against Veeramani and the other accused.

A WhatsApp number, 9345319676, has been introduced for sharing information about the affected girls. So far, five useful pieces of information have been received through the number and are being verified, the police said.

Keralam Minister's vehicle attacked; DYFI workers held

The Hindu Bureau
KANNUR

A protest by Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) workers turned violent when the car of Minister for Sports and Youth Affairs in Kerala O.J. Janeesh was attacked and damaged during a confrontation near the taluk hospital, in Taliparamba, Keralam, on Thursday.

Following the attack, the police arrested six DYFI workers.

As the Minister returned from a review meeting, DYFI workers waved black flags, raised slogans and struck his vehicle, allegedly damaging its rain guard and the flagpole on the vehicle. DYFI leaders Muhas and Prajeesh Babu were reportedly among those leading the protest.

The situation remained tense as protesters demanded the release of Muhas.

They also demanded that workers who had been

put into police vehicle at the scene be released.

The situation escalated when protesters allegedly manhandled police personnel. Following the attack, the police arrested six workers.

Meanwhile, Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala in a statement alleged that incident was part of an attempt by the Communist Party of India (Marxist) and DYFI to create unrest in the State following the loss of power.

Mahe native executed in Saudi Arabia in drug case

The Hindu Bureau
MALAPPURAM

Abbooti Valliyil, 41, from Peringadi in Mahe, Kerala, was executed at Dammam prison in Saudi Arabia on September 27 after being arrested in a drug case.

His family said he was deceived into driving a vehicle across the Saudi-Oman border on December 2, 2023, unaware that 43 kg of methamphetamine was hidden inside the fuel tank.

He was working at a mobile shop in Oman when a customer from Kannur, who had offered to help him secure a job and a Saudi visa, asked him to drive the vehicle across the border. Saudi authorities intercepted and arrested him.

Initially sentenced to 25 years in prison and fined one million Saudi riyals, he was later given the death sentence. Abbooti is survived by his mother, wife, two children, and three sisters.

The family alleged that the Kannur man admitted to the deception and offered a financial settlement, but failed to secure Abbooti's release.

His execution has renewed concern among expatriates regarding Indians facing drug-related cases in Gulf countries. For Abbooti's family, however, the immediate priority is justice. They want authorities to investigate the incident and take action against those responsible.

INBRIEF



MRPL offers ₹1.2 cr. aid to kin of employee who died in fire

Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Limited (MRPL) on Thursday announced compensation of ₹1.2 crore to the family of 30-year-old contract employee Manish Karkada, who died in a fire in the unit, while a group of contract employees carried out a protest in front of the company's gate demanding adequate compensation to the deceased and other injured persons. MRPL said it will give financial support of ₹90 lakh to the family. Besides, the family was eligible for about ₹10 lakh under Group Term Life Insurance and ₹20 lakh under Workmen Compensation Policy.

Bolarum arms theft accused wanted to sell stolen weapons

Former Army havaladar Upputholla Mallesh, accused of stealing 12 firearms and over 1,800 rounds of ammunition from the 20 Battalion, Madras Regiment premises at Bolarum, was sent back to judicial remand after his 10-day police custody ended. During questioning, Mallesh named seven others who helped him steal the cache. Investigators said the theft was driven both by Mallesh's grudge against his former superiors and an intention to illegally sell the stolen firearms and ammunition for money.

Association of Malayalam film actors gets new office-bearers

Actors Asha Aravind and Sijoy Varghese have been elected as the vice-presidents of the Association of Malayalam Movie Artistes (AMMA) in a revamp after the actors' body plunged into organisational turmoil following the general body meeting in Kochi on June 21, 2026. An executive committee meeting of the association held here on Wednesday elected them to the posts of vice-president, which had remained vacant after the resignation of actors Lakshmi Priya and Jayan Cherthala. Neena Kurup is the new treasurer and Sarayu Mohan is the new joint secretary.

Gandhi tribute



All set: Preparations under way at Hyderabad's LB Stadium for Gandhi Jayanti celebrations on October 2. G. RAMAKRISHNA

TPCC alleges pre-printed deletion forms; seeks probe

Swathi Vadlamudi
HYDERABAD

A complaint to Chief Electoral Officer C. Sudharshan Reddy by the Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) about pre-printed applications for bulk deletion of voter names in the Musheerabad constituency has opened a can of worms, adding to fears about a particular section of the electorate being targeted during the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

While allegations are being made about applications for bulk deletion of electors in Karnataka, in Telangana, fresh allegations are about an application by a booth-level agent (BLA) of the Bharatiya Jana-

TPCC raised concerns over the circulation of pre-printed application; CEO assures scrutiny

ta Party (BJP) from Musheerabad submitting Form-7 applications seeking deletion of names of the Congress's BLA and over 30 members of his family.

The names of all the family members along with the address were pre-printed on the forms, with only the name of the applicant hand-written, raising suspicions about a large-scale political conspiracy.

TPCC has raised serious concerns about pre-printed application forms being prepared and circulated on

a wider scale targeting Congress leaders and their supporters, and expressed suspicion that BLAs may have got the material through party channels. It sought thorough investigation into the matter and action against the errant.

Thorough scrutiny

Mr. Reddy said that bulk applications for deletion of electors submitted by anybody will undergo thorough scrutiny before the deletions are effected.

While Election Commission of India has clarified that any registered voter within a specific constituency could submit any number of forms, it has also said that a single person filing more than five objections will trigger a review.

Walkathon raises awareness of Neelakurinji conservation

The Hindu Bureau
IDUKKI

Keralam's Munnar hill station, the hub of the Neelakurinji bloom, witnessed a Kurinji walkathon on Thursday, to commemorate G. Rajkumar, the renowned “Save Kurinji” crusader who passed away on January 15, 2026.

Organising committee convener M.J. Babu said the walkathon and accompanying seminar raised awareness about conserving the rare Neelakurinji and its fragile ecosystem. “The programme was conducted as a mark of respect for Rajkumar, who lived for Kurinji,” said Mr. Babu.

Devikulam Sub-Collector V.M. Arya flagged off the walkathon from the old



Green measures: The Kurinji walkathon held in Munnar on Thursday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

railway station. Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forests Pramod G. Krishnan, who delivered a talk on Kurinji conservation, warned that the grasslands in Munnar are facing extinction. “We cannot imagine Munnar without the Neelakurinji, the Muthuvan tribal community, and the Nilgiri tahr,” said

Mr. Krishnan.

Meanwhile, as the commemoration took place, another Neelakurinji blooming season at Chokramudi—under the Forest Department—and at Korandakkad, within the Kanan Devan Hills Plantations (KDHP) area, drew thousands of tourists to Munnar.

President, PM hail pilot for role in averting flight crisis

Modi says without fearing for his own life, Captain Smit Machchhar fought valiantly and prevented another 9/11-like attack from happening; Murmu lauds his ‘incredible presence of mind’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday hailed Captain Smit Machchhar, a flydubai pilot, for his role in averting a disaster involving a Dubai-Tel Aviv flight on Wednesday.

An Indian national, Captain Machchhar was stabbed by his co-pilot in an alleged attempt to crash the plane but managed to activate the release to open the cockpit door, allowing passengers to enter and overpower the co-pilot. Two flydubai pilots who were passengers on the aircraft helped the aircraft make a safe landing in Tabuk, Saudi Arabia.

Mr. Modi said that Captain Machchhar had shown the world the highest form of courage. Without fearing for his own life, Captain Machchhar fought valiantly and prevented another 9/11-like attack from happening, he said.



Indian Capt. Smit Machchhar seen in the cockpit of a plane in a photo released by Israel's Foreign Ministry on social media. AP

Mr. Modi said that 140 crore Indians saluted Captain Machchhar, who is now recovering at a hospital, and were praying for his well-being. He made the remarks while addressing the centenary celebrations of the Union Public Service Commission.

President Droupadi Murmu also lauded Captain Machchhar's bravery.

“The nation is proud of Captain Smit Machchhar. His heroic courage and incredible presence of mind

have deeply touched us all. Even after being seriously injured in a moment of grave peril, he remained determined to protect the lives of others. His bravery and quick response helped prevent a major tragedy and saved many precious lives. I salute his indomitable spirit. I pray for his speedy recovery and good health,” she posted on X.

While addressing the UPSC event, Mr. Modi cautioned that future civil servants would have to navi-

gate entirely new battlegrounds such as information warfare, deep-fakes, algorithmic bias, and climate justice. He instructed recruitment agencies to adapt to these global shifts by prioritising candidates’ foresight and complex problem-solving abilities. “In such a scenario, in the selection process, we will also have to give priority to testing complex problem-solving and foresight,” he said.

Urgent reforms needed
Highlighting the urgency of administrative overhauls, Mr. Modi insisted that examination agencies must rapidly align with the nation's broader reform momentum by adopting the principle of ‘Time Certainty’ to shorten exam cycles without lowering standards. He emphasised that prolonged examinations inflicted severe financial burdens, such as coaching fees, rent, and transport, on families. “This will also be an equity reform,” he added.

With pride and prayers, Machchhar’s acquaintances await news of his recovery

Yohaana Ashish Varghese
MUMBAI

Pride over Captain Smit Machchhar's bravery aboard flydubai flight FZ1073 was tempered by an anxious wait for news of his recovery on Thursday, as childhood friends, neighbours and residents in Mumbai's Tilak Nagar, Chembur West, prayed for his safe return home.

Mr. Machchhar was hailed for his role in helping passengers and crew manage a safe landing.

The pilot was seriously injured during an attack inside the cockpit of the Dubai-Tel Aviv flight on Wednesday. Despite his injuries, he managed to unlock the cockpit door, allowing others on board to intervene.

The aircraft, carrying 174 passengers, was subsequently landed safely at Tabuk in Saudi Arabia. Machchhar underwent surgery before being shifted to Dubai for further treatment.

“It's a proud moment for all of us as Mumbaikars, as people living in the same society, and as fellow



Artist Manas Kumar Sahoo pays tribute to Smit Machchhar's bravery with a sand painting in Puri on Thursday. ANI

Indians,” said Yuhan Merchant, Machchhar's neighbour. “At the same time, we are very concerned about his well-being. We just hope that he is fine.”

Mr. Merchant, who has known Machchhar and his family, described him as “tremendously dedicated” to aviation. “We just hope that he continues doing what he does best, and that's falling in love with the aviation sector,” he said.

For Chintan, a childhood friend of Machchhar, the courage being spoken about across the world was not entirely unfamiliar. “I knew he was a very brave and large-hearted person, and today the whole world

knows it,” he said.

Neighbour Shifali Parekh said Mr. Machchhar's response showed considerable mental strength.

“Imagine getting stabbed, then thinking about the flight going down, and then opening the door,” Ms. Parekh said.

BJP MLA Parag Shah said the connection was particularly personal for him as Machchhar was not only from his constituency but had also attended the same school as him.

According to Mr. Shah, Mr. Machchhar was stable following surgery and his family was receiving assistance from flydubai and Indian, Saudi and UAE authorities.

Gujarat govt. announces award for Machchhar

Press Trust of India
GANDHINAGAR

The Gujarat government on Thursday announced that Indian pilot Smit Machchhar, who thwarted his co-pilot's alleged attempt to crash a flydubai flight despite being stabbed, will be awarded the ‘Visisht Gujarat Garima Award’ for his indomitable bravery. Officials said the pilot belongs to Gujarat, but his family had shifted to Mumbai long ago.

Captain Machchhar, who is being treated in Saudi Arabia, is being hailed for his heroic act that saved several lives, drawing high praise from all sections of society.

A special prayer has also been organised at the famous Somnath temple for his speedy recovery.

“The courage of Captain Smit Machchhar is being saluted by the entire world today. Despite being drenched in blood, he displayed indomitable bravery to save the lives of 174 passenger – a feat that is profoundly inspiring and commendable,” Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel said in a post on X.

SC refuses Mamata camp’s petition to unfreeze accounts

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday declined a petition by Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress faction to operate four bank accounts in public sector banks debit-frozen by the West Bengal Police.

Appearing before a Bench headed by Justice M.M. Sundresh, the petitioner faction argued that the first information reports (FIRs) related to the accounts’ freeze suffered from glaring procedural infirmities.

However, the Bench refused to entertain the petition under its appellate jurisdiction, and instead requested the Calcutta High Court to expedite the hearing of petitions filed

by Ms. Banerjee's faction challenging the FIRs.

The High Court had declined to provide the faction any interim relief on August 27 regarding the frozen bank accounts which hold over ₹800 crore in them.

The High Court had reasoned that any interim order of the kind would pull the rug from under an earlier direction limiting the party's access to its accounts only to meet daily or monthly expenses.

Earlier in August, the top court had declined to intervene in favour of the political party with regard to three other bank accounts frozen by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) in connection with a money laundering investigation.

Cong. leader flags ‘rushed’ scrutiny of FCRA Bill in letter to LS Speaker

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Accusing the Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) examining the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 of rushing through the deliberations without adequate consultations with stakeholders, Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal, in a letter to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, urged that the Bill should not be brought back to the floor of the House until the committee had completed a “genuine and comprehensive” examination.

The FCRA Amendment Bill, 2026 was introduced in the Lok Sabha on March 25, 2026 and subsequently referred to a 31-member JPC on August 12 following objections from Opposi-



tion parties, who contented that several provisions of the legislation were aimed at hampering the functioning of minority-led institutions.

The Opposition had especially pointed out provisions that allowed the transfer of an organisation's funds and assets to a government-designated authority if the FCRA registration was cancelled or not renewed as particularly disturbing and anti-constitutional. Instead, arriv-

ing at a compromise, the government agreed to send the Bill to the JPC.

The decision to refer the Bill to a JPC carried a clear expectation that the committee would hear a broad spectrum of stakeholders, including NGOs, charitable and religious institutions, voluntary organisations, legal experts and State governments, before finalising its recommendations, and bringing before the House “a well-considered and flawless Bill”, Mr. Ve-

nugopal said in the letter.

However, he claimed that “no meaningful consultation” with stakeholders was taking place, and that there was an intention to secure the passage of the Bill during the forthcoming Winter Session of Parliament. In an earlier letter signed by 12 of the Opposition MPs of the panel, the same concern had been flagged.

“If this is so, it would defeat the very purpose for which the House referred the Bill to the committee, and reduce an important parliamentary process to a mere formality,” Mr. Venugopal said, calling on the Speaker, as the “custodian of the House and its committees”, to ensure that the panel conducted a comprehensive exercise, and be given adequate time before submitting its report.

Top court stays death penalty of convict in Gujarat blasts case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday stayed the execution of the death sentence awarded to an Indian Mujahideen operative in the 2008 Ahmedabad serial bomb blasts case, in which 56 people were killed.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath, A.G. Masih and Sandeep Mehta passed the interim order while hearing an appeal filed by Ahmed Bawa, alias Abbu Abubakar Bareilvi, challenging the Gujarat High Court verdict affirming the death sentence imposed on him by the trial court.

The Bench issued notice to Gujarat government and called for the trial court records, while directing that the death sentence not be executed in the meantime.

Appearing for Bareilvi, his counsel contended that his conviction rested entirely on the allegation that he was part of the conspiracy behind the blasts.

“I have been convicted totally on the basis of conspiracy,” the counsel submitted.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Gujarat government, however, opposed the plea, stressing the gravity of the case.

“It is a serious case,” Mr. Mehta submitted.

On July 26, 2008, a series of 21 bomb blasts ripped through Ahmedabad in a span of 70 minutes, killing 56 people and injuring more than 200. Explosions also occurred at hospitals where victims of the attacks were being taken for treatment.

Committee on simultaneous elections Bill cancels SC visit

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The parliamentary committee examining the Bills on simultaneous elections has dropped its proposed October 6 visit to the Supreme Court for an interaction with judges. Committee chairperson P.P. Chaudhary, however, said on Thursday that the visit had been deferred because of scheduling difficulties.

The decision came after an Opposition MP wrote to Mr. Chaudhary expressing concern that any interaction with the judges on the proposed legislation could blur the separation of powers and raise questions about the institutional independence of Parliament and the judiciary.

Seeking the views of sitting judges on legislation that could later come before the Supreme Court, the MP said, could create an avoidable institutional overlap.

Bengal govt. obstructing her work as MP, says Mahua; SC seeks reply from Centre, State

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought responses from the Union government and the State of West Bengal to a petition filed by Krishnanagar MP Mahua Moitra alleging a concerted effort by the State authorities and the police, using goons and mobs, to impede her from freely accessing her constituency.

A Bench of Justices Joydalya Bagchi and V. Mohana asked Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing on behalf of both the Union and the State governments, to file counter-affidavits to the petition.

Ms. Moitra, represented by senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan and advocate Yashwant Singh, said since the shift in the State's ruling dispensation in May 2026 which saw the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) come into power for



Mahua Moitra

the first time in West Bengal, the distinction between ‘party’ and the ‘government’ had been “obliterated” in the State. Civil and police authorities had been covertly encouraged to “shun” a duly-elected Opposition MP, and “drive her out of her constituency only because of her political affiliation”.

‘Registration of FIRs’
“The new State government has made it impossible for the petitioner to function as an MP by seek-

ing to evict her from her local accommodation at the Circuit House and drive her into the hands of a politically charged mob; by holding up development works under the Member of Parliament Local Area Development (MPLAD) scheme; by not allowing her to hold any outdoor party or public meetings; tacitly allowing goons and mobs from the ruling party to physically attack her; and registration of multiple FIRs against her,” the petition said.

Any attempt by a State government to impede the functioning of a parliamentarian was a grave attack on the federal principle, Ms. Moitra said.

Civil and police authorities in Krishnanagar had, at the behest of their political bosses, refused to extend any support to her in the discharge of her duties as an MP since May 2026, she said.

Indore water contamination deaths due to institutional failure: report

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

The Judicial Commission formed to probe the death of more than 30 people due to water contamination in Indore has said the tragedy was preventable while blaming institutional failure, systematic lapses and delays in replacing the ageing infrastructure.

The one-member panel headed by former Madhya Pradesh High Court judge Sushil Kumar Gupta, who submitted the report to the Indore Bench of the High Court, flagged delays of “approximately 859+ days” in inviting important tenders, necessary approvals and completion of work in Bhagirathpura, the hotspot of the tragedy.

The probe report held the then Indore Municipal Corporation (IMC) Additional Commissioner (water supply) Rohit Sisonia and then executive engineer (water supply) Sanjeev Shrivastava “primarily



The immediate cause of contamination was the ingress of sewage into the drinking water system, said the report. A.M. FARUQUI

responsible” for several delays.

Between December 2025 and February 2026, more than 100 people suffered from ailments such as acute gastroenteritis, acute diarrhoea, vomiting, and severe dehydration after consuming contaminated water by the IMC. The tragedy claimed more than 30 lives, denting the image of Indore, which has been awarded India's cleanest city for eight consecutive years.

The report, however, links only 22 deaths to the tragedy citing hospital records.

In one pipeline project, the process, from inviting tenders to completion of the work, took 859 days, the panel said. In another tender process, Mr. Sisonia recorded only “discuss” on the file on October 15, 2025. Despite this, Mr. Srisvastava did not hold the discussion for 64 days until December 18, 2025. After the discussion, the file was

sent again on December 26 for approval to open the tender, resulting in a total delay of 72 days, the report said.

The report, however, gave a clean chit to two IAS officers and former IMC Commissioners – Dilip Kumar Yadav, who was appointed in September 2025 and removed amid the tragedy, and his predecessor Shivam Verma, who has been the Indore District Collector since September 2025.

The report also said that the IMC and the Indore Development Authority (IDA) had “failed to produce” several records, including inspection reports and documents related to laying a sewage network in Bhagirathpura between 1990 and 1995, and a drinking water supply pipeline between 1999 and 2004.

The report flagged “gross failure and administrative negligence” in preservation and transfer of public records.

Who ordered changes to Form 6, asks Rahul Gandhi

People will not forgive those who snatch their voting rights: Mamata

Plea in SC questions judge's failure to disclose his son's role as EC's counsel

Adhir Ranjan asks Mamata Banerjee to rejoin Congress

CJP set to hold protest in Mumbai today seeking CEC's resignation

BJP targets Cong. over alleged paper leak in Karnataka

A IN-Y

HEALTH

What human brain tissue transplanted into mice showed us

A Stanford University experiment called 'xenocortication' lets human brain tissue develop inside a living mouse, offering a new way to study the developing human brain and, potentially, how disease develops; it also raises new ethical questions about how far such experiments should go

C. Aravinda
Veera Rajagopal

A study published in September in *Nature* by neuroscientist Sergiu Pasca's group at Stanford University reports an experiment that sounds almost like science fiction. Human brain tissue grown from stem cells was transplanted into mice in which much of the cerebral cortex had been genetically prevented from forming. The transplanted tissue grew into this vacant space, produced several types of human brain cells, became electrically active, connected with the mouse nervous system and was associated with measurable differences in behaviour.

Yet, there was an important limitation. The researchers did not create a human brain inside a mouse. The transplanted tissue remained immature, lacked the ordered structure of a normal human cortex, and the study cannot establish that human neurons directly caused any particular behaviour. What the experiment offers is a narrow glimpse of human brain development as it unfolds inside a non-human living nervous system. Understanding how the human brain develops matters both for evolutionary biology and for medicine. The cerebral cortex expanded greatly during human evolution, developing specialised cells and connections involved in language, planning and complex social behaviour. Studying how these features emerge may help explain what makes the human brain distinctive.

It is also medically important because many neurological and psychiatric disorders may begin during development, long before symptoms appear. The main challenge is access. Scientists cannot experimentally manipulate a developing human brain as they can in laboratory animals.

Stem cell technology opened up another avenue to study the developing human brain. Scientists can take ordinary human cells, re-programme them into an earlier, flexible state called induced pluripotent stem cells, and guide them to become nerve cells. When these cells are grown together in three dimensions, they can organise into structures called organoids.

A brain organoid is a small piece of laboratory-grown neural tissue that reproduces some features of early brain development. Organoids allow researchers to observe how human neurons develop, introduce disease-related genetic changes and test responses to drugs.

However, tissue grown in a lab dish lacks key features of a living brain, including normal blood circulation, sensory inputs and long-distance connections with other parts of the nervous system. Researchers, including the Stanford group, have therefore transplanted human brain organoids into rodents. Yet this creates another constraint: the rodent already has its own cortex, so the transplanted human tissue



New findings: What the experiment offers is a narrow glimpse of human brain development as it unfolds inside a non-human living nervous system. Understanding how the human brain develops matters both for evolutionary biology and for medicine. GETTY IMAGES

must compete for limited space and neural connections, and has never amounted to more than a fragment of the host's brain.

A third window

The Stanford researchers opened up a third possibility. Instead of engineering a better graft, they re-engineered the host. Using genetic techniques, they produced mice in which much of the neocortex and hippocampus never formed. Because the mice were also bred to lack a functioning immune system, the human tissue would not be rejected. Human cortical organoids were then transplanted into the vacant space soon after birth. The researchers call the approach xenocortication. 'Xeno' refers to something originating from another species, while the cortex is the outer region of the brain involved in many higher functions.

In the Stanford experiment, freed from much of the competition from mouse cortical tissue, the human grafts expanded substantially, and by three months, they made up about 92% of the animal's cortical tissue. They produced several types of developing cortical neurons, along with progenitor cells and astrocytes, at a stage of maturity roughly equivalent to that of the human cortex late in the second trimester of pregnancy. The grafts generated deep-layer neurons carrying the molecular signature of von Economo neurons, large, distinctively shaped cells found in humans and a few other large-brained mammals, but absent in rodents.

The grafts also became electrically active, producing slow waves that swept across the tissue every few minutes, a pattern characteristic of developing, rather than mature, cortical networks. They formed connections with surviving parts of the mouse nervous system, and human nerve fibres reached as far as the

cervical spinal cord, something not seen in mice with an intact cortex. This is the conceptual leap of the study: human neural tissue was no longer a fragment lodged inside a rodent's brain, but tissue occupying almost all of the space where that animal's cortex would have been.

The next question was whether this integration had any functional effect. The starting point was itself surprising. Mice lacking most of their neocortex and hippocampus (roughly half the brain by volume) remained active and mobile.

To detect subtler differences, the researchers combined conventional behavioural tests with a machine-learning system called Motion Sequencing (MoSeq). By this measure, mice lacking much of their cortex behaved differently from normal animals. Xenocortical mice showed an intermediate pattern, suggesting that transplantation altered behaviour without fully restoring it.

Why this matters

To show what the platform can do, the researchers exposed the mice to five hours of severe oxygen deprivation. The response was confined to the human tissue: a molecular marker of oxygen stress appeared in the graft but not in the adjacent mouse brain, and not at all in animals without a graft. Two days later, the xenocortical mice walked differently, shifting to a more stable stance without any change in their speed. Imaging 10 days on showed changes in the graft's blood vessels. Under the microscope, the graft's supporting cells had multiplied and become more complex.

This creates a potentially powerful experimental pathway. Scientists could introduce a disease-related mutation into human cells, allow the resulting neural tissue to develop within a living nervous system, observe changes in cells and circuits, assess whether behaviour is affected, and then test possible

treatments. Such models could help study developmental brain disorders, the oxygen deprivation around birth that can lead to cerebral palsy, human-specific neuronal diseases and evolutionary differences between human and animal brains. They may also provide a platform for drug testing and, eventually, for evaluating regenerative or cell-based treatments for severe early brain injury.

Limits and ethics

The model is still far from reproducing a developing human brain. Although anatomical connections were observed, this does not prove that they directly controlled behaviour. Any behavioural changes, therefore, arise from a hybrid system in which human tissue interacts with the remaining mouse brain.

These scientific limits also shape the ethical questions. There is no evidence the animals developed a human-like mind, but future grafts may be larger, more mature and better integrated. At what point might this alter an animal's cognition, perception or capacity for experience in ethically significant ways? The researchers anticipated this question and consulted bioethicists at Stanford before beginning. The paper argues that going further towards grafts with mature cortical layering, or transplantation into embryos or into non-human primates, will require a greater degree of scrutiny before such experiments begin.

Ultimately, xenocortication is important not because it creates a human brain in another species, but because it may provide a third window to study human brain development.

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THE GIST

Human brain tissue grown from stem cells was transplanted into mice in which much of the cerebral cortex had been genetically prevented from forming

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Temperament, adversity may offer clues to psychiatric vulnerability: study

Afshan Yasmeen

Temperamental traits and adverse experiences during childhood may together offer clues to vulnerability to major psychiatric disorders, a transdiagnostic study by researchers at NIMHANS, Bengaluru has found.

The study, published recently in the *Journal of Affective Disorders*, examined 1,162 adults, including 532 people with psychiatric disorders, 457 unaffected first-degree relatives (FDRs) and 173 healthy controls. The participants were drawn from 393 multiplex families – families in which multiple members had been diagnosed with psychiatric disorders – involving schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, obsessive-compulsive disorder (OCD) and alcohol use disorder (AUD).

The researchers examined four broad dimensions of adult temperament – negative affectivity, extraversion/surgency, effortful control and orienting sensitivity – along with adverse childhood experiences (ACEs).

“Our findings suggest that temperament does not map onto psychiatric disorders in a simple,

one-to-one manner. Rather, different combinations of temperamental characteristics are associated with different disorders, and some of these characteristics are also seen among unaffected family members,” said Srinivas Balachander, corresponding author and one of the lead researchers of the study.

Using data from the erstwhile Accelerator programme for Discovery in Brain disorders using Stem cells (ADBS) project, (funded by the Department of Biotechnology and Pratiksha Trust), now known as the Rohini Nilekani Centre for Brain and Mind, at NIMHANS, the researchers found evidence of familial sharing across all four temperamental domains.

This was observed despite considerable variation in the psychiatric diagnoses within the same families. The finding is of interest because temperament is known to have a substantial heritable component, although the study did not directly establish that the temperamental characteristics observed were caused by specific genetic variants. “In our study, considering the significant within-family heterogeneity in terms



Finding a link: The researchers also examined whether adverse childhood experiences altered the relationship between temperament and psychiatric disorders. GETTY IMAGES

of different diagnoses, there was still a significant degree of shared temperament,” Dr. Balachander said.

Among affected participants, schizophrenia and bipolar disorder were associated with lower extraversion/surgency and orienting sensitivity. OCD was associated with higher negative affectivity and orienting sensitivity, along with lower effortful control and extraversion/surgency. Participants with AUD showed higher negative affectivity and orienting sensitivity and lower effortful control.

The researchers also examined whether adverse childhood experiences altered the relationship between temperament and psychiatric disorders.

The clearest evidence for an interaction between temperament and childhood adversity emerged in alcohol use disorder. The overall ACE score was significantly associated with AUD, and interactions between childhood adversity and two temperamental domains – extraversion/surgency and effortful control – were also

observed. “Childhood adversity appears to add another layer to the relationship between temperament and psychiatric vulnerability. In our study, the evidence for this interaction was particularly apparent in alcohol use disorder, rather than uniformly across all four disorders,” Dr. Balachander said.

The researchers, however, cautioned against interpreting the findings as evidence that a particular temperament or childhood experience causes a psychiatric disorder.

The study was cross-sectional, meaning that the assessments were made at one point in time. Reports of childhood adversity may also be affected by recall and measurement biases.

Testing the findings

To examine whether the findings extended beyond the genetically enriched family sample, the researchers tested their statistical model using an independent community-based cohort from the Consortium for Vulnerability to Externalizing Disorders and Addiction (c-VEDA).

The analysis included 2,485 adults

aged 18 to 23 years for whom the relevant temperament, ACE and psychiatric assessments were available.

The model showed an area under the curve (AUC) of 0.822 for alcohol use disorder, 0.742 for bipolar disorder and 0.752 for OCD. Its performance for schizophrenia was close to chance level, with an AUC of 0.526.

“The external validation gives us some indication that the associations identified in the family-based sample may extend to community populations for some disorders,” Dr. Balachander said.

The researchers said the findings point to the need for prospective studies that follow unaffected family members over time. Such studies could help determine whether particular temperamental characteristics precede the onset of psychiatric illness or are partly consequences of illness and its treatment.

The researchers stressed that the present findings do not establish that these measures can predict who will develop a psychiatric disorder.

(yasmeen.afshan@thehindu.co.in)



Other than outrage

Restrictions on women cannot be the answer to unsafe public spaces

There is a sickening sense of *dējā vu* in last month's headlines of sexual assaults against women and children. In the national capital alone, the gang-rape of a 17-year-old girl in Astha Kunj Park by three men posing as police personnel, the gang-rape and murder of a 16-year-old in Swaroop Nagar, and the gang-rape of another 17-year old on a sleeper bus travelling from Greater Noida to Delhi have each shocked the nation briefly before giving way to a numb outrage. Little seems to have changed in the 14 years since the candlelight marches and commissions after the Nirbhaya case unleashed a slew of new schemes, laws and funds that vowed to protect women and girls from sexual violence, especially in public spaces. The latest report of the National Crime Records Bureau shows an 80% surge in crimes against women since Nirbhaya, from 2.4 lakh in 2012 to 4.4 lakh in 2024. Some of this can be attributed to higher reporting of crimes, facilitated by those new laws and schemes, but that is not sufficient to account for the vast number of them. In 2024, more than 50 crimes against women were reported every hour, with the highest rate of such crimes seen in the metro cities of Jaipur, Indore, Lucknow, and Delhi.

The government has listed a slew of initiatives meant to deal with the problem, from the Safe City project to Mission Shakti, from a women's helpline and emergency response support system to one-stop centres for survivors of sexual violence and fast-track courts, many of which have been financed through the Nirbhaya Fund. The recent crimes, however, put a question mark on the implementation of such schemes. A safe city cannot be created simply by installing lighting and CCTV cameras, if they are not functional, monitored, and connected to a response system. Police patrols and emergency numbers matter only if they result in prompt intervention from trained and sensitised personnel. It is important to move from scheme-based policing to preventive, and outcome-based policing, with public audits of vulnerable locations with deadlines and accountability to rectify deficiencies. The justice system must address the enormous backlog of cases; the promise of speedy investigation loses meaning if survivors spend years awaiting trial. The authorities must also resist the temptation to convert women's safety into restrictions on women's freedom. The answer to unsafe public spaces cannot be that women should avoid parks after dark, return home earlier, travel only with companions, or otherwise organise their lives around the possibility of male violence. Most importantly, there is a need to challenge the culture of sexual violence and toxic masculinity, enabled by age-old patriarchal traditions.

Season's end

The IMD is conservative when it comes to projecting rainfall deficit

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) issues two forecasts – in April and May – before the monsoon. Both unambiguously pointed to a dry monsoon – confidence boosted by global unanimity that one of the strongest El Niño ever was in the offing – and the consequential question was, ‘How bad?’ It turns out that the IMD's forecast of ‘below normal’ rain (90% to 95% of average) was conservative. This was surprising, given that its models pointed to ‘deficient’ rains (below 90%). On September 30, when India's monsoon tally ended, the IMD announced 759 mm across the country, 87% of the normal 869 mm. El Niño years, when the Central Equatorial Pacific warms and suppresses monsoon rains, test a weather department's mettle because predicting the extent of the shortfall is challenging. It is perplexing why the agency opted for ‘below normal’ rainfall when it could have warned of a ‘deficiency’ and claimed accuracy. As of now the IMD can only claim technical victory because the final number sits within the 4%-5% error window. However, at a disaggregated level, the IMD's struggle with getting magnitude right is far more glaring. June got 65% of its normal, far drier than the 92% forecast. July, expected to be below 94%, ended up with 1% point more rain. August came in at 84% of the LPA, in line with the “below 94%” forecast. September at 92.4% finished a little above the forecast of ‘below 91%.’ The IMD expected a ‘normal’ monsoon in the northeast, which then recorded its driest since 1901, or 26% short. The south peninsula ran 23% short. central and north-west India – tipped to fall below normal – finished close to predictions, driven by ocean conditions and Western disturbances.

Climate change makes this more complicated. Western disturbances, extra-tropical rain-bearing systems, have been bringing more rain to India in the monsoon months, while southern India seems more vulnerable to El Niño-triggered volatility. This is reflected in *kharif* sowing. On July 10, *kharif* sowing trailed last year's by 16%; by early September the gap had narrowed to under 2%. Karnataka has declared drought in well over a 100 taluks and Maharashtra in 265 of 358, though the national deficit of about 12% is below the Centre's 20% threshold for an ‘agricultural drought.’ The IMD expects El Niño to strengthen and bring below normal rain over most of the country from October to December, threatening soil moisture and reservoir recharge. The Cabinet has lifted wheat's support price by ₹25 a quintal and mustard's by ₹413, nudging diversification. Given the consequences of IMD's forecasts, it should improve its sub-regional forecast systems and not shy from being the bearer of ill-news, if needed.

A compilation of articles, on the Editorial and Opinion pages, offering insights into the Mahatma's ideas and legacy

Gandhiji's many ways of understanding ‘genius’



Gopalkrishna Gandhi

A teacher who has held administrative, diplomatic and constitutional positions

This column is not about Gandhi as a genius (which, with a laugh, he would say he certainly was not) or about the spectacularly original man I believe him to have been. It is about the place of the word ‘genius’ in Gandhi's thought and in his writings.

Why should that common word be picked up from Gandhi's teeming English vocabulary for special attention? Because his use of that valuational word tells us a great deal about his assessment of persons and situations – a matter of interest in itself. And also because we can apply (or not apply) his yardsticks for evaluating persons and happenings in our contemporary times.

There is another non-Gandhi reason as well. Most users of the word do not know that ‘genius’ is a Latin word. Not just a word of Latin origin but a Latin word in its totality – in the way it is spelt, pronounced and meant. English has borrowed ‘genius’ from the language of Virgil, Horace, Ovid without any change whatsoever, somewhat like how C.V. Raman describes the journey of the diamond from its womb under the earth to human hands ‘...absolutely fresh...perfect from nature's crucible.’ And so, reflecting on the word, one might also ponder its travel from one language register to another, admitting some variations in its action.

Here are representative examples culled by Gandhi-researcher Murtaza Gandhi from *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi* (CWMG). Pronounced in both Latin and English identically, as Jee-nee-us, its meaning in classical Latin is ‘divine inner power’. In modern English, when used as a noun, for example ‘the genius S. Ramanujan...’, it denotes a person with exceptional intellectual or creative ability. When used as an adjective, for example, ‘the genius of India...’, it refers to a singular or unique characteristic.

The first encounter

Gandhi uses the word in both senses. His first recorded use of it is as in a skill, a vision, an act of sheer dare. He talks about it as an achievement, not as the description of a person. The reference goes back to 1888, when he was 19 years old and when his English was unpolished. Travelling by the liner *S.S. Clyde* from Bombay to England to start his law studies, he was taken up by the sight of the Suez Canal. Cutting the slender isthmus of the Suez between Asia and Africa to save on journey time by several days, it was a marvel to behold.

He writes in what is now known as his London Diary: “The construction of the Suez Canal I am

not able to understand. It is indeed marvellous. I cannot think of the genius of a man who invented it. I don't know how he would have done it.” (CWMG, Vol.01, p.11). The ‘man who invented it’ is, of course, Ferdinand de Lesseps (1805-1894), a French diplomat and entrepreneur, who thought of and made the Canal with the help of two engineers – the Austrian Alois Negrelli and fellow Frenchman Linant de Bellefond.

In this year, 2026, which marks the 70th anniversary of the 1956 Anglo-French-Israeli bombardment of Egypt which aimed to take over the Suez Canal – which Egypt's President Gamal Abdel Nasser had nationalised, – Israel is using more lethal bombs with prodigal abandon in Palestine and Gaza and, with the United States joining the fire-play over Iran, causing the death, among others, of the Supreme Leader of the Iranian state, no less. So, today, we can reflect on Gandhi's marvelling at the genius that went into the making of that oceanic passageway only with anxiety for the future of the area around that marvel.

The dark side

This brings one to a phrase which is twinned to ‘genius’: evil genius (or malignum genium). The earliest known use of that phrase as a concept is in French philosopher Rene Descartes' use of it in his 1641 opus *Meditations on First Philosophy*. He posits in it the existence of a power that is the very opposite of the divine power that actuates ‘genius’ – evil genius, a malignant God or evil power.

By 1893, Barrister M.K. Gandhi was in South Africa and soon became the spokesman and leader of the Indian community there in its strivings for the recognition of its rights and its dignity. Stung by the discriminations and humiliations that Indian South Africans were subjected to, particularly at the hands of the Asiatic Department, we see him use the word not just in its simple sense of a compliment but in its contrary avatar: “There seems to be somewhere in the Asiatic Department of the government an evil genius working through it.” (CWMG, Vol.04, p.26, 23. The Bazaars in The Transvaal) .

‘Evil genius’ occurs in Gandhi's vocabulary again when he is back in India, where he uses it in the context of the Jallianwala Bagh massacre (April 13, 1919) but very pointedly for an individual: “General Dyer has been haltingly blamed, and his evil genius, Sir Michael O'Dwyer, entirely exonerated...” (CWMG, Vol.19, p.339). Just stopping short of using the phrase ‘evil genius’, he invokes the word witheringly with sarcasm, to

describe the British Raj's policy of ‘Divide and Rule’: “But just now I am speaking of the genius of the Government. It has not hesitated to divide Hindus from Muslims in order to be able to retain its hold on us.” (CWMG, Vol.19, p.398, Speech at Nankana Saheb – March 3, 1921).

As a term of praise

The earliest recorded reference by him of a person as a genius in a wholly complimentary sense, is for Lokamanya Bal Gangadhar Tilak who, in 1916, in the town of Belgaum, famously declared (in Marathi) “Swaraj is my birthright and I shall have it.” The ‘Father of Indian Unrest’ had been dead four years but addressing the Indian National Congress' session in the same town of Belgaum in December 1924 as Congress President, Gandhi could not but refer to him and said (in English): He was the genius of swaraj (CWMG, Vol.25, p.508, Concluding Speech at Belgaum Congress, December 27, 1924). Gandhi is doing something very interesting here. He is terming Tilak as a genius of and in something very singular, very specific – swaraj. He is using the term very precisely, very contextually, like he would be if he were to describe Einstein as a genius of the Theory of Relativity.

The next most notable use by him of the word as a personal tribute is for Rabindranath Tagore. Speaking on him in 1931, Gandhi says: “In common with thousands of his countrymen I owe much to one who by his poetic genius and singular purity of life has raised India in the estimation of the world.” (CWMG, Vol.45, p.125, Tribute to Rabindranath Tagore – January 26, 1931).

He was to use the word for him again but again, not as a direct adjective but with a value added: “His creative genius has also given us Santiniketan, Sriniketan and Visvabharati” (CWMG, Vol.84, p.124, Speech at Prayer Meeting, May 8, 1946).

There is one person for whom Gandhi uses the word ‘genius’ without any niche that encases ‘genius’. It is for his friend and almost-preceptor, the young Bombay-based jeweller, poet, Jaina ascetic Rajchandra or Raychandbhai as Gandhi called him: “Kavi Rajchandra was born in a place called Vavania in Kathiawar... His schooling was quite elementary. But he was a genius. He knew Sanskrit, Magadhi and, I believe, Pali” (CWMG, Vol.43, p.98, A Great Seer – March 18, 1930).

Genius can do marvels and do evil. Remembering Gandhi's awareness of that truth is today not a matter of language alone but of life and death.

The Mahatma's unfinished work on the world stage

Writing about Gandhiji's death on his birthday may not be an entirely odd thing, given how he died and how that conflicted with what he stood for. In popular perception, Gandhiji was a tired, old man whose life's work was over when he was assassinated.

In any case, the people he sought to train and transform into compassionate human beings had turned bigoted murderers or condoned bigotry and mass murder during Partition. The last eccentric, going-against-the-grain act they allowed him was fasting in favour of Pakistan. Revisionist history of today seeks to downgrade his role in India's freedom by counterposing Netaji.

But it can be argued that Gandhiji's best years were yet to come even if India had failed him then and now. At 78, Gandhiji was healthy enough to have gone on a village-to-village walk in Noakhali, fasted for three days in Calcutta to stop the rioting before the five-day Delhi fast, and talked about a fast-unto-death to stop the killing of Muslims in Bihar. His health may well have facilitated his shining on the world stage for several more years.

The emergence of a global image

Gandhiji had already ascended the world stage a few decades before in-part due to the rapid growth of print media in the first half 20th century that sought out new and novel stories. Among a non-violent campaign's advantages were that it was carried out in the public domain, transparently – far easier to cover than a clandestine plot. A report on the Dharasana beatings ran in some 1,300 papers worldwide. And photos of Gandhiji, with his dress, or the lack of it, quirks and eccentricities, looked great on newsprint.

Among the many influences Gandhiji had globally was the Black civil rights movement. In America, African-American newspapers were only eager to see parallels and seek inspiration. And it was not symbolic or philosophical but direct and tactical, too. A Harlem ashram and an Ohio ahimsa farm sprang up. Even the



M. Kalyanaraman

Had the Mahatma lived, his message of non-violence might have travelled further and shaped global movements

goat-milking transmuted to America.

Martin Luther King may have been the most famous of civil rights leaders' visits to India but there were many other organisers such as Bayard Rustin and James Lawson who had immersive sojourns in India. A report in *The Hindu* quotes Rustin – he was the organiser of the 1963 March on Washington, at which King delivered the “I Have a Dream” speech – as saying in 1948 that the “Indian non-violent revolution has much to teach us”.

During the Montgomery Bus Boycott, described as the practical kick-off of the civil rights protests led by King, Rustin put his learnings to successful use. He insisted that Montgomery should only be one of many such sites. He ticked off King for having armed guards in his house, saying that Gandhiji would not do that. In a move that caught the attention of many, but which Rustin owed to Gandhiji's methods, he asked that the leaders should go and voluntarily surrender to the police, saying that, yes, they had broken the law, but that it was the right thing to do. Lawson set up a Satyagraha training school in Nashville.

Non-violence on a global scale

Gandhiji did become a global icon, posthumously. For sure, his methods drew from the past. A peaceful march organised by a priest in St. Petersburg was violently put down by the Tsar although it triggered the 1905 revolution. But what was new was that Gandhiji showed that they were duplicable on a mass scale in an organised manner. This was the novelty that caught the imagination of the world later.

Scholars have shown that in the latter half of 20th century, when asymmetries of power solidified, only non-violent campaigns could succeed and did so. East Timor was a sterling example.

Perhaps the best chance that the Palestinians had for Swaraj was in the initial stages of the Intifada. Though known more for the

stone-throwing, the initial protests were largely non-violent but forceful in a Gandhian way. More than all the bombings, assassinations and the plane hijacks engineered by the Palestinians, it could be argued that Intifada 1 forced the Israeli leadership to negotiate and at least on paper commit to a two-state solution eventually though subsequent events upended all that.

It would seem that Gandhiji had planned on playing an active global role after India's Independence. A report in *The Hindu* on March 9, 1948, quotes Horace Alexander as saying that Gandhiji, in England in 1931, had told his friends

that when India would be free, he would take part in a world movement for spreading the gospel of non-violence. Another report in August 1947 says that “discussions are now going on between Mahatma Gandhi and some of his American, Indian and European friends” for the world conference.

The conference was held in 1949, a year after his death. International participants discussed setting up an organisation. A.J. Muste wanted to set up a training institute in India. But, without the man himself, Gandhiji became only a soul force, not a physical presence, for non-violent activists across the world.

The Palestine test

If idle speculation could be allowed, a living Gandhiji would have electrified the world that had just gone through a monstrous war and the Holocaust. Instead of becoming just a memorial possibility and vague idealism, non-violence and compassion would have been far more rooted in global discourse.

The best test for Gandhiji would have been Palestine.

If he could make an Englishman ashamed of himself, could he not have made Israeli Jews ashamed of inflicting on Palestinians the suffering Jews had endured for centuries?

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A balance

The new NCERT Class 9 Social Science curriculum significantly reduces the space given to modern European history, replacing chapters on the French and Russian Revolutions. At the same time, it places a much-needed emphasis on Indian history, exploring traditions of governance,

sacred responsibility, and regional resistance and resilience. The inclusion of the *Sengol* provides an opportunity for students to learn about India's civilisational continuity and political traditions. Since the historical interpretation of the *Sengol* remains contested (inside pages, October 1), it is vital that

textbooks present competing accounts with adequate evidence. In an age shaped by global change, our education system must seamlessly combine cultural rootedness with rigorous historical inquiry and critical thinking. **Sathiyapriya Kumar**, Thirukkattupalli, Tamil Nadu

Numbers must work

In my experience, several official telephone numbers published on the Tamil Nadu government websites are either ‘switched off, not reachable, or remain unanswered’. These numbers are provided specifically to enable citizens to contact the government offices

concerned for information, clarification or assistance. The official CM Helpline information states that citizens should be able to access grievance services without having to visit a grievance centre and provides multiple channels, including telephone, online portal, mobile application and email to *Mudhalvarin*

Mugavari. Therefore, there appears to be a clear disconnect between the citizen-friendly services announced by the government and the actual accessibility.

Balamarthandan D., Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Should the EC take action against those filing forms for mass deletions?



Ashok Lavasa
Former Election Commissioner



Prasenjit Bose
Congress leader and petitioner in West Bengal SIR case in Supreme Court

PARLEY

As Phase 3 of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls unfolds, a surge in Form 7 applications, the mechanism for seeking deletion of names, in Karnataka has raised concerns. More than 4,000 such forms were filed in the State, with 1,363 in one place coming from just 10 electors, many reportedly targeting Muslim names. Uttarakhand has seen objections filed in an Electoral Registration Officer's (ERO) name without his knowledge, while in West Bengal, data shows that nearly 90% of Form 7 applications were accepted. Similar cases have been reported by *The Hindu* from Rajasthan and Gujarat as well. Should the Election Commission (EC) take action against those filing forms for mass deletions? Ashok Lavasa and Prasenjit Bose discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Sreeparna Chakrabarty**. Edited excerpts:

What is the ERO legally required to do when a Form 7 arrives?

Ashok Lavasa: Under the Registration of Electors Rule 1960, all the steps that are required for registration, for deletion, and for amendment are listed. Form 7 applications are typically used to object to the entry of a person in the electoral roll. As soon as a Form 7 notice is received by the ERO, the Rules prescribe that first of all they should be put on the notice board for the public to know that objections have been received against such and such person. After this, a specific notice is to be given to the person against whom a complaint has been received. The Rules provide that in case an inquiry is demanded, the ERO or the officer designated cannot take a decision on his own without conducting a formal inquiry in which he can even summon the complainant and the person against whom the complaint has been received. He can ask the complainant to testify under oath that the particulars that he is presenting and the documents that he is giving are true. He is also informed that in case this is found incorrect, there is a penalty under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act (RPA) for which he can be penalised with imprisonment for giving false information. This is the procedure. The spirit behind this is that no name should be deleted without giving adequate opportunity to the person against whom a complaint has been received.

How do these bulk forms emerge and is there a limit on how many objections one person can file? Also, can Section 31 of the RPA, which penalises false declarations, be



Karnataka CM D.K. Shivakumar staged a sit-in protest demanding an inquiry into alleged voter list deletions through bulk Form 7 submissions, outside the office of the Chief Electoral Officer in Bengaluru, on Thursday. PTI

invoked if somebody files bulk Form 7s?

AL: I think the EC has issued instructions from time to time; it is not given in the Rules as such. But instructions have been given that you should not receive more than, I think, five or six forms according to current norms. With respect to Section 31, I don't think it can be invoked. It is specifically to do with giving false information.

In Karnataka's Babaleshwar, 1,363 of Form 7 applications came from just 10 electors. Reports have said that many of the deletions targeted Muslim names.

AL: Clearly, this is a misuse of the procedure. The concerned authorities need to act against people who are misusing the system. You would recall that in Karnataka last year, when the Leader of Opposition had given some instances, the EC had itself clarified that out of some 2,000 odd applications that it received, only roughly 28 had been found to be correct. The question here is that we still do not know whether the EC has proceeded against somebody for making a false declaration. This penal provision, to the best of my knowledge, has hardly been used against anyone. And unless there is a deterrence, this provision will lose its efficacy.

West Bengal has seen one of the highest rates of acceptance of Form 7s. What is the petition against this in the SC about?

Prasenjit Bose: There are specific formats in which aggregated data on all Forms – 6, 7 and 8 – have to be recorded and disclosed at the end of any revision period by the EC. But that has not been followed in most States, especially in West Bengal. So, we had to request for the disclosure of that data because we found anomalies in the data that were disclosed during the claims and objections period.



There are specific formats in which aggregated data on all Forms – 6, 7 and 8 – have to be recorded and disclosed at the end of any revision period by the EC. But that has not been followed in most States, especially in West Bengal

PRASENJIT BOSE

As per the facts revealed by the affidavit filed by the EC in response to the petition that we had filed, the total Form 6 applications for inclusion were 34 lakh, out of which 7,26,000 were rejected. As far as Form 7 is concerned, the total number received was 6,39,000, which by itself, if you compare with States of similar sizes such as Bihar or Tamil Nadu, is on the higher side. And out of the 6,39,000 Form 7 applications received, 5,72,000 were accepted. So, you have an almost 90% rate of acceptance of Form 7 and less than 21% for Form 6. This anomaly is quite glaring. The problem lies in the deterrence mechanism of Section 31 of the RPA.

In many cases, the person in whose name the forms were filed denied having knowledge of the same. Is there some central mechanism which can be used to file forms?

PB: I will give you the latest example from Uttarakhand. I have on record, the ERO of Haridwar Rural constituency confirming that he has not submitted any Form 7 filed in his name. In one constituency, 3,500 Form 7 applications were submitted just hours before the window of claims and objections were about to get over and all the objections were in the name of the ERO. It has been done in an automated manner.

A similar mechanism was used in West Bengal vis-a-vis the appellate tribunals where automated appeals for exclusion have been filed which one of the Election Commissioners had flagged. Judicial intervention is needed to stop this as these illegalities are depriving genuine electors from their right to vote.

AL: This is quite absurd and calls for a probe. Clearly, the ERO cannot file objections. Although in the Rules there is a provision that the ERO can make some corrections on his own, that does not amount to filing so many objections.

And it is the responsibility of the Chief Electoral Officer of the State and the EC to thoroughly investigate this matter. However, just because applications are filed, we should not condemn the system. I think we need to actually hold the system accountable.

As far as the centralisation of data or

generating objections in a centralised fashion is concerned, I think we are speculating. There is no evidence of that. But, we do know that one of the Election Commissioners has actually red-flagged the issue saying that it creates the possibility of manipulation at the central level.

What can be done to deter this?

AL: I think there are some safeguards in place, but the point is whether they are being enforced. The EC generally after filing FIRs is not following them up systematically because it is presumed that now this is the responsibility of the concerned law enforcement machinery. This is where the EC needs to put in place a very strong monitoring mechanism. Earlier, I have suggested that the National Crime Records Bureau must have a separate data set on election-related crimes. And they should be reported separately so that all these figures are in the public domain. Once this data is in the public domain, people will analyse and flag these issues. The EC also has certain internal norms such as if in any polling booth, there are more than 2% additions or deletions, that particular booth is taken up for greater scrutiny. In all these instances where we are saying that 2,000 or more applications were received, the point is whether the system is accepting them. Is it actually leading to unjustified removal or addition? And finally, whether the system is taking note of the possibility of misuse.

PB: My point is that if the institution itself which is supposed to uphold the law and administer it, if at least a section within that institution starts violating the law, then the entire system breaks down. I think that is what has happened. In terms of reform, what has happened is that the electoral laws, RPA Act and especially these Forms were framed at a time in the 1950s and 60s. It was a non-digital era. Today we have digital databases and online submission of Forms. I think our laws have become out of sync with the way the process is being conducted today. There is a need for legal reforms.

In terms of reform, what has happened is that the electoral laws, RPA Act and especially these Forms were framed at a time in the 1950s and 60s. It was a non-digital era. Today we have digital databases and online submission of Forms. I think our laws have become out of sync with the way the process is being conducted today. There is a need for legal reforms.

AL: If people are committing fraud that obviously cannot be dealt with under the RPA. This is a weak link in the system; our law-and-order machinery is not taking these cases seriously. That is why I suggested there has to be a specific monitoring mechanism for electoral offences.



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A reflection on two songs and their nationalisms

While it is customary to garland Gandhiji on his birthday, this year, let us listen to him instead and to the song he lived by. At a time when the Republic has spent 10 months legislating about another song, the contrast will be a lesson in what nationalism is, and what it is not.

The song the Republic legislated about is *Vande Mataram*. In January 2026, the Union Home Ministry directed that all six stanzas of the National Song be performed at official functions, with everyone standing at attention. In July, a second order made the six-stanza text the “official version” and placed the Song before the Anthem.

Parliament amended the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, to bring the National Song within the ambit of criminal law for the first time. To intentionally prevent its singing, or to disturb an assembly engaged in singing it, now invites imprisonment of up to three years.

On September 22, the Supreme Court heard the Carnatic musician and author, T.M. Krishna's challenge to the law and the orders. It did not decide the case. It asked the Union government to reply. However, Justice Joymalya Bagchi said that while the state may decide whether the Song has two stanzas or six, *Bijoe Emmanuel* (the SC judgment which upholds the right to religious freedom, constitutional tolerance and silent objection) still governs. A conscientious objector, to one stanza or all, should face no criminal consequences if she/he respectfully stood but didn't sing. Justice Bagchi's view is not yet a judgment but one wishes it should be.

The same morning, the Solicitor General answered the plea for national consensus by stating that law-making cannot follow the ideas of Naxalites. This author, in court for another matter, rose to say that to think, is not to be a Naxalite.

The episode matters only because it sums up the two nationalisms discussed here: one answers an



Sanjay Hegde
Senior Advocate of the Supreme Court of India

We have a National Anthem, protected by law, and a National Song, honoured by usage. Let the Republic recognise *Vaishnava Janato* as our National Prayer

argument, the other renames the arguer.

Vande Mataram

Let us take a closer look at the six stanzas of the Song; Bankim Chandra Chatterjee wrote the first two around 1875, reportedly as a filler for his journal. They are a hymn to a landscape, richly watered, bountiful, and cool with southern breezes. Any Indian of any faith can sing these stanzas about her nation.

The later stanzas came with his novel *Anandamath*, and they name names. The motherland becomes Durga with her 10 weapons, Lakshmi, and Saraswati. It is two songs stitched together, and the divide has run through our politics since 1905, when the Partition of Bengal made its opening words the war cry of *Swadeshi*.

The freedom movement resolved the problem sharply. In October 1937, on a resolution moved by Rajendra Prasad and seconded by Vallabhbhai Patel, the Congress Working Committee acknowledged the validity of Muslim and others' objections to the later stanzas and adopted the first two alone for national gatherings.

Rabindranath Tagore, who had first set the song to music, blessed the change. He loved the opening stanzas and disowned the theology that followed.

On January 24, 1950, India's first President Rajendra Prasad announced that *Jana Gana Mana* would be the National Anthem and that *Vande Mataram* would be “honoured equally”. Honour is not an obligation and for 55 years, the law protected the Flag, the Constitution and the Anthem, and deliberately left the Song outside the penal net. Love for the song was invited and obedience was never demanded.

Nor was the two-stanza settlement any insult to Bankim. The Bhagavad Gita is seven hundred verses from a Mahabharata of a

hundred thousand. Our national anthem is the first of Tagore's five stanzas. Fitting a work to a public purpose is homage and not a denigration.

This settlement worked. In 1997, A.R. Rahman, born a Hindu and a convert to Islam, reimagined *Vande Mataram* as *Maa Tujhe Salaam*. Ask anyone under 40 to sing *Vande Mataram* and you will hear Rahman.

It is this settlement of 1937, of 1950, and of 1997 that the current orders and statutes have reopened, and that the Supreme Court has now, rightly, handed back to the state and to us.

The other song

Five centuries before Bankim, Narsinh Mehta of Junagadh was excommunicated by his own caste for singing among

‘untouchables’. He composed *Vaishnava jana to tene kahiye, je peed parai jaane re* (Call that one alone a man of God, who knows another's pain as his own). The song has no map, no enemy, no throne. It audits a human being: one who serves without pride, bows to all and disparages none, keeps word, deed and thought in one line, looks on all with an equal eye, tells no lie, touches no wealth that is not his, honours every woman, and has put away deceit, lust and anger.

Read that against the Constitution and you will find that Narsinh drafted a version of the Preamble early and set it to music.

Feeling another's pain is fraternity assuring the dignity of the individual. Bowing to all is Article 14. The equal eye is our secularism and the hand that refuses another's wealth is the law of probity. The tongue that will not lie is the informed citizen of Article 51A.

Gandhi carried it from Sabarmati to his last prayer meeting, beside the Koran and Christian hymns, and in a hundred years no one has felt excluded by it.

Vande Mataram tests your posture; *Vaishnava Janato* tests your

conduct.

Here, then, are two songs and two nationalisms. One venerates the soil and asks the citizen to bow. The other civilises the soul and asks citizens to be worthy. One now comes with a sub-inspector attached. The other has never needed one.

A modest proposal

So, on Gandhi Jayanti, here's a proposal. We have a National Anthem, protected by law, and a National Song, honoured by usage. Let the Republic recognise *Vaishnava Janato* as our National Prayer, through the gentle method used in 1950, and not the muscular method of 2026. No order, no penalty, no compulsory standing. Only recognition and no mandatory requirement. Let it be sung, by those who wish, where the National Song is sung.

Let schoolchildren learn its meaning in every language. A prayer compelled is no prayer at all. That is the point.

Bankim's third stanza counted “*sapta koti kantha*” – the seven crore throats from his motherland, an undivided Bengal. In 1905, Sarala Devi sang it as thirty crore, and the motherland became India. Today we are 140 crore, and every crore was added by inclusion; none by compulsion.

A choir of 1.4 billion cannot be conducted with a *lathi* (stick). In a symphony that size, the conductor's only instrument is the willingness of the singers, won by making everyone feel the song is theirs. Inclusion is not a concession to the fastidious. It is the better tune.

The Constitution does not demand that we all worship the same way. It demands that we remain, all 140 crore of us, equal citizens. We are better off not insisting that everyone sing our song, and instead praying that everyone becomes a *Vaishnava jana* in citizenship.

Standing at attention takes 90 seconds. Feeling *peed parai* (pain of others) takes a lifetime and it, not the standing, is what builds a nation.

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 2, 1976

New watches with Swiss assistance

As there was no issue dated October 2, 1976 from the issue dated October 1, 1976

New Delhi, September 30: A Horological Institute is likely to be set up in India with Swiss assistance for training Indian personnel in the highly sophisticated technology of watch-making to meet the vast domestic demand which is expected to reach ten million pieces a year by 1980.

A Swiss delegation is arriving shortly for follow up discussions on a phased programme for importing components and assembling them in India during the first stage, obtaining machinery for making these components and finally making the machines in India itself for achieving near self-sufficiency both in design and production for keeping pace with the rapid technological advances in the industry.

The HMT, which has already acquired the necessary expertise in watch manufacture with Japanese collaboration will be able to complete this three-phase programme in the next few years if an agreement is reached with the Swiss industry soon. A high-power Indian delegation visited Switzerland for preliminary discussions.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 2, 1926

The Madras Monegar choultry

The following appeal has been issued by the Board of Directors of the above Choultry:—

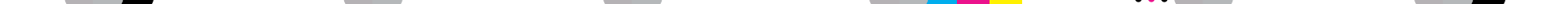
The object of this charitable institution founded in the year 1782 to provide for the living of those who had been thrown in distress on account of the disastrous results of the invasions of Hyder Ali from Mysore, and latterly of old and helpless persons who had no other means of subsistence, is well-known to the public.

This laudable object was accomplished without interruption, but owing to the crippled financial condition of this humanitarian institution, the number of paupers who were receiving shelter and support therein have had to be considerably reduced with the result that while there is accommodation for 140 persons, only 80 men and women can at present be supported by it.

THE HINDU

11 in per cent. Coal India Limited said the supply of dry fuel to the power sector users has increased by 11.01% to 148.20 million tonnes (MT) in the second quarter of the current financial year. The supply has firmed up ahead of the festive season and is likely to help ensure adequate availability of coal at thermal power plants, CIL said. **PTI**

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

CM YK  A IN-X

FULL CONTEXT

The forgotten villages at the heart of Delhi’s urban history

Delhi’s villages were integral to the city’s history, but colonial surveys, land acquisition and urbanisation transformed their land and communities; as Delhi expands, preserving the heritage and living traditions of Delhi *Dehat* remains a challenge

Shekhar Tokas

On September 11, 1803, on the banks of the Yamuna at present-day Patparganj in East Delhi, the British East India Company forces defeated the Maratha army and gained control of Delhi. It was a decisive turning point in the city’s history. The battle marked not only a shift in political power but also the beginning of a new phase of surveying, mapping and appropriation of Delhi’s rural landscape.

The rural landscape before the Raj
At the beginning of the 19th century, Delhi was dotted with distinct ecological zones. The fertile *khadar* stretched along the Yamuna, while the *pahari* tract occupied the natural triangle formed by the Aravalli hills to the north, south and south-east, with the river defining its eastern boundary. To the south-west lay the low-lying *dabar* around the Sahibi river, while the fertile agricultural plains of the *bangar* marked the north-west. These zones were home to village communities whose livelihoods centred on cultivation and animal husbandry, with cattle, camels and goats forming part of everyday rural life.

For centuries, these agrarian settlements supplied food, labour, water, military recruits, artisans and cultural traditions to successive urban centres. These settlements were not peripheral to Delhi’s history. They were part of what made the city possible. The *Ain-i-Akbari* records the region’s crops, revenues and land conditions, including Palam, which contributed 5,726,787 dams in revenue. Govil’s study of Siraspur (1803-1880) similarly shows the village’s close links with Delhi through land, revenue and property relations. Siraspur, now in North Delhi near Samaypur Badli and Rohini, survives as a reminder of this once-extensive rural hinterland.

From village land to colonial property
With the British consolidation of Delhi after 1803, the countryside entered a new phase. From 1837, revenue surveys began to map, classify and regulate village lands – including fields and commons (*shamilat deh*) – with a degree of systematic documentation that transformed customary rights into colonial administrative categories.

But Delhi’s villagers were never simply anonymous cultivators. They had their own systems of landholding, cultivation, kinship, lineage and customary rights, supported by institutions of village life. *Bhats* preserved these histories through genealogies that recorded ancestry, settlement and links between families and land. Gradually, however, colonial records – *shajra naksh*, *khasra* and settlement registers – became the state’s official records of land and rights.

The 1880 settlement of Kanjhawala shows what was at stake. Around a quarter of the recorded land was held as common land, supporting grazing and other collective needs. As these commons were later classified, divided and transferred, the change was not merely administrative. It reshaped the relationship between Delhi’s village communities, their land and the collective resources on which rural life depended. Every map broadly divided village land



The rural landscape of Munirka village in 1959, viewed from the site of present-day Priya Park. The havelis of Munirka and a tomb are visible. The R.K. Puram Sectors 4 and 5 can also be seen, marking the early stages of urbanisation in the area. MISSION FOR INDIAN HISTORY AND ARCHAEOLOGY, UNIVERSITY OF TOKYO, IN 1959-60

into three types: *abadi deh*, the village settlement; *zari/pahāi arāzi*, agricultural or hilly land; and *shamilat deh*, village commons. The *shajra naksh* showed the village and its different parcels of land, while each parcel was identified by a number, known as a *khasra* number.

These were more than administrative maps. Read alongside the *shajra nasab*, *jamabandi* and *khatauni*, which documented lineage, land rights, ownership and cultivation accounts, these records revealed patterns of settlement, landholding and kinship. Together, these records made village land easier for the colonial state to identify, assess and regulate. Four land-revenue settlements followed, culminating in 1880. The British systematically surveyed and mapped individual fields, assigning numbers that linked land to revenue and ownership records. For village families, land held through generations was increasingly documented not through *bhats*, customary knowledge and community relationships, but through official field numbers and assessed revenue. Ancestral rights were thus drawn into a formal colonial system of property and fiscal control. In 1880, *Zaildari* and *Nambardari* further extended this system of revenue collection. Delhi District was organised into three tehsils, 44 zails and hundreds of villages, including 375 villages across 18 zails in the area broadly corresponding to present-day Delhi.

The 1908 Lal Dora system further formalised village boundaries by separating *abadi* from agricultural land. After Delhi became the imperial capital in 1911, land acquisition transformed this system of control into large-scale displacement. Around 30 villages lost land for New Delhi, including Raisina for the Viceroy’s House, Khairpur for what became Lodhi Garden, and Pilanji and Malcha for parts of Chanakyapuri. Raisina remains a striking example: its agricultural land was acquired in 1911-12, and more than a century later,

descendants continue to seek compensation in the Delhi High Court.

After independence, another transformation followed. The state increasingly acquired agricultural land while leaving village *abadi deh* intact. As fields gave way to roads, institutions and neighbourhoods, the rural landscape gradually disappeared from official maps and from the historical consciousness of the expanding city. The settlements remained, producing the paradox of the “urban village” - rural settlements engulfed by urbanisation. The supposedly “unplanned” urban village, therefore, is not outside Delhi’s planning history; it is one of its products.

Whose history is remembered?
But the story of Delhi’s villages is not only a story of land. It is also a story about what gets remembered as history. Why do we remember Delhi through its kings, empires, monuments and imperial buildings more readily than through the villages and communities that surrounded them? History is not simply the past; it is the way the past is remembered, interpreted and represented. Historians reconstruct the past from fragments of surviving evidence, and the past is always larger than the evidence that survives.

Collingwood’s *The Idea of History*, Bloch’s *The Historian’s Craft*, and Carr’s *What Is History* remind us that history is not simply found in archives; it is reconstructed through questions, evidence and interpretation. This has an important implication for Delhi *Dehat*. Its history lies not only in official records but also in village maps, land documents, landscapes, material remains and oral memories.

The history of Munirka, as reconstructed in *Mhara Munirka: Story of an Urban Village*, illustrates this process. The book brings together oral histories, accounts preserved by *bhats*, old British-period maps, land acquisition documents and surviving structures such

as *havelis*, ponds, wells, *chaupals* and temples to recover the history of the village.

The *bhats*, who preserved genealogies and memories of families and their ancestry, provide an important source for recovering histories that may not appear in official records. Recovering these sources allows us to see Delhi not merely as a planned metropolis, but as a city shaped by villages whose histories have often remained outside its dominant narrative. The absence of Delhi’s villages from dominant histories does not mean they have no history. It raises a deeper question: whose experiences and sources have shaped the historical record?

The future of Delhi Dehat
Delhi’s villages were never leftover spaces waiting to be urbanised. They helped make the city. As Delhi plans for 2047, the question is not simply how these villages will be absorbed, but what happens to their communities, heritage, livelihoods and remaining commons. Will future planning protect their *abadi*, historic structures and local institutions, or displace them once again? Delhi’s future will depend not only on what it builds, but on what it chooses to retain.

Even the term *Dehat* deserves reconsideration. The distinction between *shahar* and *dehat* obscures the continuities between rural and urban Delhi. Katwaria Sarai village, surrounded by IIT Delhi, the Indian Statistical Institute and the Qutub Institutional Area, still retains its *jhod* (pond), *akhada* (traditional wrestling pit), Guru Gorakhnath *Mandir*, *Valmiki Mandir* and *Daulat ki Haveli*. Across Delhi, villages continue to preserve rurality through their built heritage, festivals, rituals, language, food and everyday practices. Delhi *Dehat* is therefore not a space outside the city, but a living part of it. (Shekhar Tokas is an Assistant Professor of Urban Studies at Dr. B. R. Ambedkar University Delhi)

THE DAILY QUIZ

A quiz on the Father of the Nation on his 157th birth anniversary

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1
Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi had three siblings. If Raliyatbehn was the sister, who were the two brothers?

QUESTION 2
It is said that when he embarked for England, Gandhiji carried a letter of introduction to a cricketer who was a schoolmate. Name this sporting legend.

QUESTION 3
An incident that took place on the night of June 7, 1893, acted as a catalyst for Gandhiji to fight against race and colour prejudices. What and where?

QUESTION 4
Name the two main ‘ashrams’ set up

by Gandhiji in South Africa.

QUESTION 5
After many campaigns, activities and arrests in South Africa, Gandhiji returned to India for good on January 9, 1915. How is the date commemorated now?

QUESTION 6
Who was responsible for giving Mohandas Gandhi the title ‘Mahatma’, and who first referred to him as ‘Rashtriyapitha’ (Father of the Nation)?

QUESTION 7
Which genius paid this wonderful tribute to Gandhiji: “Generations to come will scarce believe that such a one as this ever in flesh and blood walked upon this earth”?



Visual Question:
Name the famous gentleman seated alongside Gandhiji. THE HINDU ARCHIVES

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. Name the place from where Baba Budan is said to have brought coffee beans to India, and how has the place’s name become part of coffee lore? **Ans: Mocha in Yemen, and a chocolate-flavoured coffee is called mocha**
2. What is the biggest contribution of Melitta Bentz and Achille Gaggia to the modern world of coffee brewing? **Ans: Paper coffee-filter system and espresso machine**
3. After which event did drinking coffee acquire a particularly patriotic significance among some American colonists as an alternative to tea? **Ans: Boston Tea Party of 1773**
4. What is the common name for the coffee species called ‘Coffea canephora’? **Ans: Robusta**
5. Which famous brand was officially launched in 1938 to help surplus Brazilian coffee crops? **Ans: Nescafé instant coffee**
6. Which famous composer wrote a comic opera called ‘Coffee Cantata’? **Ans: Johann Sebastian Bach**
7. What is the name given to a trained professional who prepares espresso-based and other coffee drinks? **Ans: Barista**
Visual: This expensive coffee consists of partially digested coffee cherries that have been eaten and defecated by which animal? **Ans: Asian Palm Civet**
Early Birds: K.N. Viswanathan | Tariqa Bali | Tito Shiladitya | Sunil Madhavan | Tamal Biswas



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of “It isn’t worth a hill of beans”? (J. V. Subba Rao, Hyderabad)

When you say something “isn’t worth a hill of beans”, what you are implying is that it is insignificant; it is worthless. This is an expression which is normally used in informal contexts.

What is the difference between “homicide” and “murder”? (R. Ganesan, Madurai)

“Homicide” is a word frequently used in American English. It refers to the killing of one human being by another. The killing may be accidental or intentional. If you shoot a man accidentally or in self-defense, it would be considered “homicide”; similarly, if you run over an individual intentionally, it would be considered “homicide”. It is a neutral term. According to Black’s Law Dictionary, the word homicide merely “describes the act; it pronounces no judgment on the moral or legal quality”.

Murder, on the other hand, is an illegal act; it is usually a premeditated crime. When an individual “murders” someone, he/she kills another human being after having planned what he/she is going to do. The word “murder” has a negative connotation associated with it. The police force in the United States has a Homicide Department, but not a Murder Department. The “o” in the first syllable of “homicide” is like the “o” in “hot”, “pot”, and “not”, while the “i” in the second syllable is like the “a” in “china”. The final syllable is pronounced like the word “side”. The main stress is on the first syllable.

Is it ok to say “I am running forty”? (K. Chandrasekaran, Sivaganga)

We Indians are always in a hurry. When we are on the road, we are in a rush to get somewhere; sometimes totally ignoring all traffic rules. So it is not surprising that we are always “running” some particular age. It is very common to hear an Indian say that he is “running 40”. I suppose when one is 39, one can run to 40. But when one is 79, does one run/jog/canter/limp/crawl to 80? I have no idea. The expression “running 40” is common within the Indian context. Native speakers tend to use “going on”. Remember the famous song from “The Sound of Music”? “I am sixteen going on seventeen”. Is it wrong to say “running 40”? Within the Indian context, it is acceptable.

What is the meaning of “the straw that broke the camel’s back”? (A Vara Prasad, Tuni, A.P.)

When you say that something is the straw that broke the camel’s back, what you are implying is that you have reached the limit of your patience; that you are not willing to put up with any more nonsense.

Sriram is always late for office. On Friday, he failed to meet an important client. That was the straw that broke the camel’s back. The boss fired him.

It is also possible to say “the last straw”. For example,

When he broke the window for the third time, it was the last straw.

There is a limit as to the amount of straw that any animal can carry. A camel, for example, can carry a certain amount on its back. If you keep adding to the amount, then the animal will become overloaded. That final straw is the straw that breaks the camel’s back. The idiom has been in use since the mid 1800s. Published in *The Hindu* on February 26, 2002

Word of the day

Subterfuge:
something intended to misrepresent the true nature of an activity

Synonyms: deception, trickery, deceptiveness, secrecy

Usage: *His excuse was just subterfuge to hide what he had really done.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/subterfuge

International Phonetic Alphabet: /sʌbtəˈfjuːʒ/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

INBRIEF



Govt. warns private fuel retailers over sales cap

Imposing caps on retail fuel sales is not acceptable and the government will take up the matter with private oil-marketing companies, Petroleum Ministry Secretary Neeraj Mittal told reporters in response to queries over diesel purchase limits imposed by private retailers Jio-bp and Nayara Energy. “Nobody is allowed to put a cap on sales. We will take it up with them and tell them it is not acceptable,” Mr. Mittal said.

ICICI Prudential Life’s Bagchi named HDFC Bank MD, CEO

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI), has approved appointment of Anup Bagchi as the Managing Director & Chief Executive Officer (MD & CEO) of HDFC Bank for a period three years with effect from October 27, 2026. Mr. Bagchi, a seasoned financial services leader with over three decades of experience across banking, capital markets, wealth management and insurance, will replace Sashidhar Jagdishan.

Coal India’s production jumps 9.2% in September

Coal India’s production rose 9.2% year-on-year to 53.5 million tonnes (MT) in September, while supplies grew 12.5% to 61.2 MT. Supplies to the power sector, its largest consumer, increased 10.6% to 48.9 MT. Supplies to the non-regulated sector rose 19.4%. The state-owned miner said sustained operational momentum has strengthened its confidence in meeting its FY27 production target of 815 MT and supply target of 850 MT.

GST revenue rises to ₹2.03 lakh cr. in Sept.

An analysis of historical Goods and Services Tax data shows that an increasing share of GST revenues have been coming from tax paid on imports rather than GST collected on domestic transactions; share of revenue from domestic transactions has correspondingly fallen to its lowest-ever level

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The Centre’s gross Goods and Services Tax (GST) revenue rose to ₹2.03 lakh crore in September 2026, a growth of 14.7% over the last year. However, the data also points to a changing trend of where India is earning its GST revenue from.

An analysis of historical GST data shows the share of revenues from imports has risen to its highest-ever level, while the share of revenue from domestic transactions has correspond-

ingly fallen to its lowest-ever level.

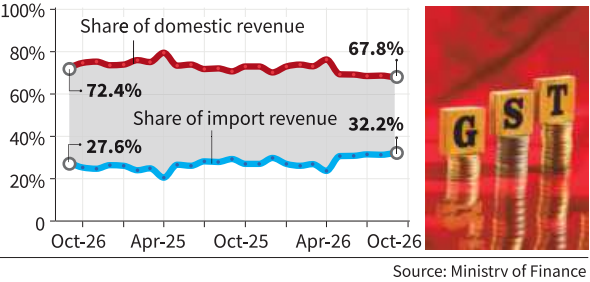
Over the first half of the financial year, spanning the April-September 2026 period, gross GST revenue grew at 11.6%.

“The increased focus on reducing complications and the increasing number of GST audits undertaken this year appear to be yielding results in the form of the gross monthly GST collection once again crossing the Rs 2 lakh crore mark,” M.S. Mani, partner at Deloitte India said.

“It is especially remarkable to see the gross GST

Changing composition

A rising share of gross GST revenue is coming from imports



Source: Ministry of Finance

collections growing by 14.7% and the net GST collections growing by 18.1% compared to the same month last year despite

last year being on higher GST rates compared to the current year,” he added.

However, within the gross collections, the data

Goyal, Greer deliberate ‘early conclusion’ of trade treaty

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Thursday said that he had held a meeting with U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer on the sidelines of the G20 Trade Ministers’ Meeting in the U.S. Mr. Goyal said that the two leaders discussed the “early conclusion” of an interim agreement under the India-U.S. Bilateral Trade Agreement.

While Mr. Goyal did not mention discussing the proposed 100% tariffs that the U.S. is looking to levy on India, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal had



Commerce Piyush Goyal with U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer.

earlier said that “all trade issues” would be discussed by the Minister during his visit to the U.S.

“Met USTR Jamieson Greer on the sidelines of the G20 Trade Ministers’

Meeting in Milwaukee,” Mr. Goyal posted on X on Thursday morning. “Had a productive discussion with USTR Greer towards early conclusion of a mutually beneficial interim agreement under the India-U.S. Bilateral Trade Agreement.”

The two also exchanged views on G20 deliberations under the ongoing U.S. Chairship, he added.

Mr. Goyal also held a meeting with Maroš Šefčovič, the European Commissioner for Trade and Economic Security.

“Reviewed progress towards the signing and entry into force of the India-EU FTA,” Mr. Goyal said.

Manufacturing PMI touches 7-month high of 55.1 in Sept.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Manufacturing activity rose to a seven-month high of 55.1 in September, according to a private sector survey. However, activity in the second quarter was the weakest since the COVID-19-impacted Q2 of 2021-22.

That said, September’s performance marked a significant recovery as the HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers’ Index rose by 2.3 index points from its 52.8 reading in August 2026.

A reading above 50 denotes expansion in activity while one below 50 implies

Stronger demand for electronic, food, pharma products drove a sharper rise in new business

a contraction. “September data showed a recovery in growth momentum across India’s manufacturing industry, with faster increases in new orders and output supporting job creation and inventory accumulation,” the report said.

“Moreover, business confidence strengthened to a four-month high.”

“That said, the average for the second fiscal quar-

ter stood at 53.8, its lowest since the same period in 2021,” it added.

Respondents said that stronger demand for electronic, food, pharmaceutical, and textile products drove a sharper increase in new business, with the upturn in total sales the fastest since February 2026.

“New export orders also expanded at a quicker pace, with panel members particularly noting greater demand from clients in Brazil, Europe, the UAE and the U.S,” the report said. “This pick-up in demand momentum spurred the sharpest expansion in Indian factory production for four months.”

Anti-multilateral trade deals may hit growth, exports: govt. economists

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Economists in the Ministry of Finance have warned that bilateral and regional trade deals that seek to replace the current multilateral trade system could lead to “greater trade diversion, higher trade costs, and greater uncertainty”.

However, while India was pursuing a diversified trade strategy, it was doing so within multilateral trading system and still sought to have the World Trade Organization (WTO) at the core of such a system, say the economists.

The Monthly Economic Review for September, prepared by economists in the Department of Eco-



‘Network of FTAs’ system can cut global GDP, exports.

nomics Affairs, cited the WTO’s recent report that sought to predict what would happen to the world economy by 2050 under three different trade-related scenarios.

“According to the WTO’s World Trade Report 2026, in a ‘geo-fragmented world’ scenario, in which

trade is organised around geopolitical blocks, global GDP is projected to decline by 5.1%, and global exports by 18.6% relative to the baseline in 2050,” they said.

Worst of scenarios

The worst of the scenarios would be a ‘Free Trade Agreement (FTA) world’ in which the multilateral trading system is replaced by a network of FTAs with tariffs on non-FTA partners in a non-cooperative way. If this comes about, cuts in global GDP and exports were estimated by WTO at 6.9% and 26.9% each.

“In an ‘enhanced cooperation world’ scenario, wherein multilateral cooperation is reinforced, global GDP and global exports

are projected to rise 2.9% and 17.9%, respectively.”

Therefore, the report concluded regional and bilateral trade pacts can provide additional market access and complement the multilateral system when they operate within the WTO framework. However, the costs of such trade deals turn higher when they take place outside the multilateral framework and used to substitute it.

“In such a situation, market access turns more dependent on the terms negotiated between partners while trade outside the arrangements faces less favourable conditions. This results in greater trade diversion, higher trade costs, and greater uncertainty.”

Whither nature



Cost of development: A worker rides a donkey carrying goods at the seafront in Lamu Old Town on Lamu Island on Thursday. The picturesque Kenyan island of Lamu faces a tough trade-off after becoming the construction site for Africa’s latest mega-refinery, being built by Nigerian tycoon Aliko Dangote. AFP

PNG Drive 3.0 to add 50 lakh connections

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI



Hardeep Singh Puri

Union Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, along with the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) and city-gas distributors, unveiled National PNG Drive 3.0 to boost shift to piped natural gas (PNG) for households.

The latest phase, which will run until the end of FY27, targets 50 lakh new domestic PNG connections, conversion of 40 lakh existing connections into active consumers and onboarding 50 lakh domestic PNG registrations.

The initiative builds on the second phase, which ran from January 1 to June 30, 2026 and added about 13.4 lakh billed connec-

tions, while generating more than 15.3 lakh domestic PNG registrations.

PNGRB data showed a sharp acceleration in adoption during phase 2. Average daily additions of domestic PNG connections rose 43% to 6,690 from 4,702, while those of billed consumers rose over 2.5 times to 7,392 from 2,781.

Households must concentrate more on long-term savings in pension: CEA

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Chief Economic Adviser V. Anantha Nageswaran on Thursday called for a shift in household investment behaviour from short-term trading to long-term savings, and said investment in long-duration pension assets is crucial for financial security in old age.

He called for a partnership between PFRDA, financial intermediaries and households to encourage long-term investing, which may be less exciting than short-term trading but provides durable and sustainable financial security and peace of mind post retirement.

Addressing the NPS Di-



Anantha Nageswaran

the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) is focussing on retirement income schemes, drawdowns and an assured payout so that people, after 60 years of age, have the option to convert the pension corpus into steady income that lasts for as long as the person lives and one that keeps pace with prices or inflation.

Of the ₹18 lakh crore corpus as of September under the National Pension System (NPS), about 47% is invested in government securities, 28% in equity, and 21% in corporate debt.

Recalling Lord Yama’s message in the Katha Upanishad, Mr. Nageswaran said life’s moments ask us to choose between ‘The Shreya’ – the enduring good, and ‘The Preya’ – the fleeting comfort.

A contribution to a pension account is a small, repeated choice of Shreya over trading in futures and options at very narrow frequencies and short frequencies, he said.

“It’s equally important for the average household and the head of those households to understand that

while short-term trading may be exciting, it is the long-term savings in long-duration assets that provides for the family’s health and well-being when he or she stops earning,” Mr. Nageswaran said.

Speaking at the event, Financial Services Secretary Sanjay Lohiya said pension fund managers need to be mindful of the responsibility with which they need to manage the pension corpus of subscribers.

“It’s one thing to manage a debt fund or a mutual fund and another thing to manage a pension fund. In a normal investment in a mutual fund or a share market or even a debt fund, their horizon is hardly a few years,” he said.

Sept. PV wholesales grew in double digits

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Passenger vehicle (PV) wholesales continued to grow in double digits in September led by market leader Maruti Suzuki India on strong demand.

Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. (MSIL) sold 2,36,013 units in September, a 24.43% year-on-year (YoY) growth. Partho Banerjee, senior executive officer, marketing & sales, MSIL said, “The new plant is helping us to increase our supplies resulting in, increasing the number of wholesales.”

Hyundai Motor India Ltd. wholesales stood at 77,916 units a 10.8% growth. Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles wholesales climbed 15% to 70,210 un-

its. Mahindra & Mahindra’s automotive division logged wholesales of 64,092 SUVs, a 14% increase.

EV milestone

“Adding to this, we are proud to have crossed the milestone of one lakh billing of our electric origin SUVs since launch,” said Velusamy R., president, automotive business, Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd.

JSW MG Motor India reported 8,018 units in wholesales in September, registering 19% growth.

“The strong performance reflects sustained consumer interest in the firm’s product portfolio, including the recently-launched MG Hector To-mahawk EV and PHEV,” the company said.



The U.S. launched AI chatbot America.gov on Tuesday to simplify access to govt. info and services. FILE PHOTO

U.S. govt.'s new AI bot pulls back from debunking Trump

Agence France Presse
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump unveiled what he called a “damn good” AI chatbot, but it quickly drew attention for contradicting some of his contentious political claims. A day later, however, it stopped answering some political questions.

“Hello, America. Whatever you need from government, start here,” reads the America.gov platform, which Mr. Trump launched on Tuesday in a bid to simplify access to government information and federal services.

The chatbot soon began contradicting Mr. Trump on controversial subjects such as the 2020 presidential election, which he wrongly claims to have won, and the January 6, 2021 insurrection that saw a violent mob attacking the U.S. Capitol.

“On its first day, America.gov harnessed facts and official documents to contradict some of the false narratives and political framing about immigration and elections heavily promoted by the administration that built it,” said the Digital Democracy Institute of the Americas. “Initial analyses found that America.gov generally provided evidence-based answers backed by government records, even when those records contradicted claims made by Trump and his administration.”

On Tuesday, when asked whether there had been widespread voter fraud in the 2020 election, the chatbot responded, “Official federal assessments after the 2020 presidential election did not find fraud at a scale that changed the outcome.”

On Wednesday, however, the chatbot changed its tune when asked the same question. “I do not provide political commentary or analysis of past elections,” it said. It was unclear whether the administration had tweaked the settings to prevent the chatbot from debunking the President.

Trump, Vance ramp up campaigning as Republicans brace for midterm polls

Trump's trips to Texas and Oklahoma kicks off what the President said will be a 32-day campaign blitz; Vance will be stumping in Florida, putting the party's highest-ranking officials in areas where GOP candidates once expected to have glide paths to victory but are now facing much tougher races

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

President Donald Trump and Vice President J.D. Vance both hit the campaign trail on Thursday, but they headed to heavily Republican areas to shore up lagging enthusiasm in their party ahead of next month's midterm elections.

Mr. Trump's travel on Thursday to Texas and Oklahoma kicks off what the President said will be a 32-day campaign blitz leading up to November 3. Mr. Vance will be stumping in Florida, putting the Republican Party's highest-ranking officials in areas where GOP (Grand Old Party) candidates once expected to have glide paths to victory but are now facing tougher races.

A new poll from The Associated Press-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research finds that only 17% of U.S. adults approve of Mr. Trump's handling of the cost of living. Just 26% approve of his handling of the economy overall, marking a new low.

Republicans have expressed growing pessimism about their chances in the election, which will determine control of Congress, as the President has repeatedly dismissed concerns about high costs and gas prices as his unpopular war in Iran drags on.

According to Mr.

Trump, his party's headwinds are merely a matter of poor public relations about a job he says is well done. “We're not getting the word out,” he told reporters on Wednesday. “I mean, we're just not getting it.” That's why, he said, he will be travelling all over and trying to persuade GOP voters to pretend his name is on the ballot. “I'm going out because nobody's selling it,” Mr. Trump said.

Delanie Bomar, a spokesperson for the Republican National Committee, said in a statement that “the President is barnstorming the country, energising our base, and supercharging Republican candidates in battleground districts and beyond. We have the resources to spend, and Republicans are full steam ahead to protect and expand our majorities.”

‘Full-on panic mode’

The Democratic National Committee (DNC) said Mr. Trump and Mr. Vance are “desperately trying to rally their base as the midterm elections approach and Republicans face defeat.” “Donald Trump and J.D. Vance started a deadly and costly war with Iran that sent the economy spiralling and pushed prices even higher, and now – in the final stretch to the midterms – they're desperately pleading with voters to ‘give [them] another



Donald Trump says his party's headwinds are merely a matter of poor public relations about a job he says is well done. REUTERS

chance,” said DNC deputy communications director Kendall Witmer.

In Oklahoma, Mr. Trump will campaign with Republican Mike Mazzei, who is running against Democratic State House Minority Leader Cyndi Munson in the race for Governor.

Democratic Governors Association spokesperson Kevin Donohoe said Mr. Trump's campaign rally shows that Republicans “are in full-on panic mode.” “This race continues to get more competitive – and national Republicans are right to be worried about Mazzei,” he said.

The event will be held on the Choctaw Nation of Oklahoma, putting Mr. Trump in the company of just a handful of U.S. Presidents who have visited tribal nations while in office.

Before his evening Okla-

homa stop, Mr. Trump will tour a truck manufacturing facility in Texas, where Republicans are spending heavily to try to bolster state Attorney General Ken Paxton in a Senate race.

Mr. Paxton faces a very competitive challenge from Democratic State Representative James Talarico. Mr. Paxton was planning to be with Mr. Trump at the official White House event Thursday in Denton, two campaign officials familiar with Mr. Paxton's plans said.

Mr. Trump will be campaigning in more politically competitive areas in the days and weeks ahead as he embarks on his travel blitz, but Republican officials will not send him to places where they think his presence could drag down their candidates, according to a person familiar with the party's strategy who was not authorised to speak publicly and spoke on the condition of anonymity.

Mr. Trump's Oklahoma visit, and likewise one on Friday to Alabama, are aimed at hitting two targets with one stop, the person said. Republican officials have noted that Durant is close to the Dallas and Fort Worth media market, meaning Mr. Trump's message will also be carried to Texas voters, and he's expected to talk about Mr. Paxton even while addressing voters in the neighbouring State.

His Friday stop in Mobile, Alabama, is aimed not only at boosting Senator Tommy Tuberville as he runs for Alabama Governor but also at shoring up support in Florida's adjacent panhandle for Republican Representative Byron Donalds. Mr. Donalds is running for Florida Governor against David Jolly, the Republican-turned-independent who is now running as a Democrat.

Mr. Donalds' campaign in heavily GOP Florida comes as Republicans there have faced some turbulence and voter concerns about affordability and artificial intelligence data centres have become central issues.

While Mr. Trump is in Oklahoma and Texas, Mr. Vance will stump with Mr. Donalds in central Florida on Thursday. Mr. Vance's visit to Lakeland comes a day after the Vice Presi-

dent campaigned in Texas. He rallied with Republican candidate Eric Flores, who is in a tight U.S. House race in south Texas.

Mr. Vance, on Wednesday, acknowledged broader discontentment over the high prices in the U.S. but shifted the blame away from Mr. Trump and Republicans. “I know there are people out there who are frustrated by the pace of progress,” he said, but “we have spent every single day fighting for you, digging ourselves out of the hole that Joe Biden left us in.”

Mr. Trump will also campaign on Saturday in Vandalia, Ohio, and on Monday in Grand Island, Nebraska.

In a meeting on Capitol Hill this week, White House chief of staff Susie Wiles described privately to GOP senators that Mr. Trump will have a near-daily sprint of campaigning ahead of the November 3 midterms.

Ms. Wiles showed Republicans the President's upcoming travel schedule, which attendees described as extensive and almost every day, all across the country.

West Virginia Republican Senator Shelley Moore Capito said White House officials are “acknowledging the headwinds” but that “they have a strategy, and we have a strategy,” including money that the President's operation will continue to deploy.

Latvia election expected to keep EU course as threat from Russia looms

Agence France Presse
RIGA

Latvians vote Saturday in an election dominated by the threat from Russia, and despite progress made by populist and protest parties, they are expected to confirm the country's pro-European and pro-Ukrainian course.

The Baltic state is a key pillar of NATO's eastern defensive flank, and experts say there is widespread support for supporting Ukraine in the war with Russia.

“The stance towards Russia is the main reason for Latvians' Western, NATO and European anchoring,” a Western diplomat in Riga told AFP, adding that it would be hard to imagine



Poll fever: A campaign poster in Riga, Latvia, featuring PM Andris Kulbergs ahead of the general elections on Saturday. REUTERS

major political changes.

Polls predict the centre-right United List, led by Prime Minister Andris Kulbergs, will emerge the largest party in Parliament on Saturday's vote.

But his centre-right coalition, which also brings together the centrist New

20th century.

Roberts Kits, an analyst at the Latvian think tank LaSER, said “defence and security will be the priority”.

Apart from a few dissenting voices, he said, there is broad consensus on maintaining military spending at nearly five percent of GDP and on supporting Ukraine.

But the economy is also a major concern for voters.

Latvia is the least affluent of the three Baltic States in terms of living standards, despite catching up since joining the EU in 2004. Growth is sluggish, with voters pointing to the cost of living, the state of the healthcare system and the difficulties of public finances.

A loaded locker



Opening doors: An envelope is retrieved from an ‘Abortomat’ — Poland's first-ever abortion locker allowing women access to abortion pills — located right across the street from the Polish Parliament in Warsaw. The installation allows anonymous access to pregnancy-terminating pills in a country with some of Europe's strictest abortion laws. AFP

Troops to trade: France and Chad quietly rebuild ties after military rupture

Agence France Presse
PARIS

Nearly two years after French forces in Chad were abruptly shown the door, ties are quietly being rebuilt through business, diplomacy and a more discreet security partnership.

Relations with its former colonial ruler soured sharply in November 2024 when Chad tore up a defence pact with Paris, ending six decades of French military presence in a strategic location for regional security.

The surprise move marked a further blow as the largely desert nation was France's last foothold in Africa's Sahel region after the forced withdrawal of French troops from Mali, Burkina Faso and Niger

in the wake of military coups.

But after months of tensions, N'Djamena and Paris say they want to reset a relationship that has long been dominated by security concerns.

Two Chadian Ministers were in Paris last week for a business forum involving 250 companies looking to invest in the Sahelian nation. The idea is to “demilitarise” and “diversify” ties, a French source with knowledge of the matter told AFP.

“We want to show [Chadian President Mahamat Idriss Deby Itno] that we're serious when we say we want to develop the economic relationship,” the source, who spoke on condition of anonymity, said.

Chad's ambassador to

France Amina Priscille Longoh was similarly upbeat. “The momentum is very positive... consultations are regular and there is mutual consideration. We feel we are being heard,” she told AFP.

The optics have changed too. Finance Ministers and business executives in suits and ties are now at the forefront of exchanges, replacing the military fatigues that once defined relations.

Quiet return

The thaw began in January when Mr. Deby was received at the Elysee Palace and again met French President Emmanuel Macron at the Africa Forward Summit in Nairobi in May.

The two leaders spoke of a “revitalised partner-



Ties soured in 2024 when Chad tore up a defence pact with Paris, ending 6 decades of French military presence in the nation. REUTERS

ship”, while Chad described economic cooperation as a priority.

With the public focus on trade and investment, security ties have also resumed behind the scenes.

Landlocked Chad is surrounded by violence-wracked Central African

year, which French sources also confirmed.

In April, a team of French officers travelled to N'Djamena to assess the Chadian military's needs in training, intelligence-sharing and capacity-building.

French officials insist there will be no return to the days when Mirage fighter jets and up to 1,500 French troops were based in the country. Several military sources described the process as “cautious” and “gradual”, although occasional deployments of French combat aircraft have not been ruled out.

According to the Chadian officer, French personnel already in the country are working with Chad's main intelligence agency. “They leased an ISR aircraft,” he said, refer-

ring to intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance missions.

Chad hopes France will also eventually provide a “small fleet of reconnaissance aircraft” to help monitor its vast borders, he added.

Turkish drone troubles

Mr. Deby has spent recent years diversifying Chad's security partnerships, forging closer ties with the UAE and Turkey. But regional events have left him in a tight spot.

The war in neighbouring Sudan has shaken regional alliances, while Chad still faces threats from Boko Haram in the west and armed groups based in Libya and Niger.

Officially neutral, Mr. Deby has nevertheless

been accused by Sudan's Army of helping channel Emirati arms to the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces. N'Djamena also received around \$700 million in Emirati loans and direct financing in 2023 and 2024.

Chad had also hoped Turkish-made drones would replace some of the aerial surveillance and combat capabilities lost when the French military left. But “things haven't gone as planned”, according to a source with knowledge of the matter.

Some drones have reportedly been grounded repeatedly because of \$50 million in unpaid bills, the source said, although a Chadian officer denied the claim and praised the “impeccable” devices.

DREAM FINAL

India thrashes Sri Lanka, sets up gold-medal match with Pakistan



Defending champion India hammered Sri Lanka by 124 runs in the Asian Games men's semifinal in Nisshin on Thursday to set up a gold-medal clash with Pakistan. **The scores:** India 169/7 in 20 overs (Sooryavanshi 38, Kishan 80 n.o., Ratnayake 2/32, Arachchige 2/28) bt Sri Lanka 45 in 9.5 overs (Bumrah 2/7, Axar 2/8, Abhishek 2/2).

FALLING SHORT

Indian squash teams end up with bronze after semifinal defeats



Defending champion India lost 1-2 to Malaysia in the Asian Games men's semifinals, the lone win coming from Veer Chotrani, *in pic*. The women met the same fate against Hong Kong despite Tanvi Khanna's stirring comeback. The defeats ended the country's squash campaign in the team event with two bronze medals.

UNBEATEN SO FAR

India makes quadrant semifinals, assured of sepaktakraw medal



India was assured of a sepaktakraw medal in the men's quadrant competition in Nagoya on Thursday after it entered the Asian Games semifinals with a 2-1 win over Myanmar, keeping an unbeaten run intact to top Group A. India had earlier defeated Laos and Vietnam in its first two matches.

BLISTERING SHOW

Second-placed Pranavi's 63 puts India in twin medal hunt



Pranavi Urs fired a blistering seven-under 63 in the second round that catapulted her into sole second place (11-under 129), two shots behind leader Shannon Tan of Singapore, in the women's golf competition at the Asian Games in Nagoya. The women's team is now in the bronze-medal position at seven-under 273.

India holds off Pakistan in a thriller, enters final

The defending champion lets slip a three-goal lead before Abhishek's last-minute strike saves the day for the team; Malaysia ousts South Korea to reach the gold-medal contest

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan

GIFU

Relieved. The pre-dominant feeling in the Indian camp after sneaking past Pakistan 4-3 in the men's hockey semifinal of the Asian Games here on Thursday. A game of two halves and seemingly two different Indian teams turning up for each half.

With the scores tied 3-3 and 49 seconds to go, a shoot-out looming large in the first semifinal at the Gi-fu Prefectural Green Stadium, Abhishek's feeble push took a deflection off Sufyan's stick and the Pakistan team watched the ball roll past the goal line, crushing their dreams of advancing to the title clash yet again.

For the first 30 minutes, India played like the higher-ranked defending champion it is, despite a distinct lack of fluidity. The fifth



Man of the moment: Abhishek is the toast of his teammates after his winner. R.V. MOORTHY

saw Harmanpreet Singh slot the ball into the middle of the net and take the lead. By the 23rd minute it was 3-0, despite a goal being disallowed for coming off the back of Dilpreet's stick.

Pakistan, which had pulled one back 35 seconds from half-time through its sixth PC and skipper Abu Mahmood,

came out pumped up and took charge. Two goals in four minutes exposed the Indian fragility. Hannan Shahid tapped in in the 45th minute and Rana Waheed Ashraf restored parity, capitalising on a defensive lapse.

A fifth Asian title and a spot in the LA Olympics will be on the line when India takes on Malaysia in the

first-ever Asian Games final between the two sides after the latter got past Korea 2-1 in the other semifinal.

The results (semifinals): India 4 (Harmanpreet Singh 5-pc, 13-pc, Sukhjeet Singh 23-pc, Abhishek 60) bt Pakistan 3 (Abu Mahmood 30-pc, Hannan Shahid 45, Rana Waheed Ashraf 49); Malaysia 2 (Abu Kamal Azrai 40-pc, 45-ps) bt Korea 1 (Gangsan Lee 42).

Nitesh wins silver in 97kg Greco-Roman wrestling

Uthra Ganesan

NAGOYA

Nitesh Siwach went down fighting in the final of the 97kg Greco-Roman wrestling but the 23-year-old had made history much before he stepped on the mat in the title clash. He became the sixth Indian Greco-Roman wrestler to reach the final of the Asian Games and the first in 64 years, the edition when the discipline was first introduced.

Nitesh began in style, winning 7-1 against Turkmenistan's Amanberdi Agamammedov in the quarterfinals. All his points were scored in the first three-minute period.

The semifinal was even more lopsided, Nitesh bulldozing his way past Mongolian Gankhuyag Ganbaatar 9-0.

Two massive four-point moves and then one for pushing his opponent off the mat were enough for the two-time Asian Championships medalist to storm into the final against



History-maker: Nitesh with coach Hargobind Singh after his remarkable display. PTI

local favourite Yuri Nakazato, last year's silver medalist at the Asians.

It was a close bout, Nakazato earning two single points in the first period for a narrow lead. Nitesh tried to counter in the second but ended up conceding two more to lose 0-4.

"I still can't believe it. My father told me there was no looking back once I started this journey and today I did it for him. There was a lot of pressure but I trusted my training and gave everything I had to make the country proud,"

Nitesh said after the bout.

In 77kg, Aman had to fight hard to win 8-6 against Borgil Tuvshinbaatar of Mongolia, courtesy a two-pointer in the last few seconds after trailing for long periods.

However, he went down tamely in the quarterfinals to Qatar's Shahin Badaghimofrad 0-9.

On the women's side, Mansi first went down 0-6 to Japan's two time World champion Nonoka Ozaki in the 62kg semis before losing 2-5 to Mongolia's Altjin Togtokh in the bronze medal match.

Ganesh earns bronze in compound archery

Press Trust of India

NAGOYA

Indian compound archer Ganesh Mani Ratnam Thirumuru defeated Vietnam's Cong Duc Dang 149-144 in the men's bronze-medal playoff after a 144-148 semifinal loss to Kim Jongho of South Korea. Ganesh had defeated Taiwan's Chieh-Lun Chen 148-138 in the quarters. Among women, Chikitha Taniparthi lost 143-144 to Indonesia's Nurisa Dian Ashrifah in the last-eight stage.



Ganesh. REUTERS



Going strong: Noble and Francis in action. REUTERS

Francis-Noble clinch silver in men's skiff

Press Trust of India

GAMAGORI CITY

The Indian pair of Manu Francis and Prince Kurisinal Noble bagged the silver medal in the men's skiff opening race 9 of the Asian Games sailing competition here on Thursday.

The 31-year-old Francis and the 30-year-old Noble, who hail from Ernakulam and are first cousins, combined for a total of 23 points after nine races and finished behind China's Wen Zaiding and Liu Tian, who totalled 16 in the competition where the lowest total wins the regatta.

Points in men's skiff sailing are decided by the finish position in each race and a first place brings in one point to the total. The Indians managed to win race three and finish second in race one, five and nine. China emerged on top in four races to end up as the best-placed side.

In the women's competition, Harshita Tomar and Shital Verma ended fourth and last after logging 26 points. Japan took gold with 11. The Indian combination could not win any of the nine races but managed to finish second in race three and four.

INDIANS IN ACTION		
A look at some Indian players/teams who will compete on Friday (all times IST):	semifinal: vs. Iran (10.55 a.m.); Medal matches (11.25 a.m. onwards).	Volleyball: Men (classification match 5th-8th): vs. South Korea, 6.30 a.m.
	Boxing: Finals: Women: 75kg: Lovlina vs. Ziyi (Chn), 10 a.m.; 65kg: Parveen vs. Nien-chin (Tpe), 2.15 p.m.; Men: 80kg: Ankush vs. Minseong (Kor), 2.45 p.m.	Wrestling: 1/8 finals: Women's 50kg: Dipanshi vs. Susaki (Jpn), 7.05 a.m.; Men's freestyle 125kg: Rajat vs. Kassimbek (Kaz), 7.25 a.m.; Women: 76kg: Priya vs. Kyzy (Kgz), 7.30 a.m.; Men's freestyle 65kg: Sujeet vs. Zazai (Afg), 8 a.m.
	Mixed team semifinal: vs. Japan (8.20 a.m.); Medal matches (8.50 a.m. onwards); Men's team	
	Archery: Recurve: Women's team semifinal: vs. China (5.55 a.m.); Medal matches (6.25 a.m. onwards).	

THE INDIA SHOW		
A look at some Indian performances on Thursday:		
Archery: Compound: Men's individual bronze medal match: Ganesh bt Dang (Vie); Women's individual quarterfinal: Chikitha lost to Ashrifah (Ina).	Hockey: Men (semifinal): bt Pakistan 4-3.	Tennis: Men (quarterfinal): Nagal lost to Yibing (Chn) 4-6, 4-6.
Cricket: Men (semifinal): bt Sri Lanka by 124 runs.	Sailing: Men's skiff: Manu & Prince (silver).	Volleyball: Men (quarterfinal): lost to Pakistan 0-3.
Golf: Individual (round 2): Men: Saptak (T7), Veer (T16), Yuvraj (T22); Team: Fifth; Women: Pranavi (second), Diksha (T21), Aditi (T25); Team: Third.	Sepaktakraw: Men's quadrant (Group A): bt Vietnam 2-0, bt Myanmar 2-1.	Wrestling: Men's Greco-Roman: 97kg (final): Nitesh lost to Nakazato (Jpn).
	Shooting: 25m rapid fire pistol men individual final: Anish (seventh).	77kg (1/4 final): Aman lost to Badaghimofrad (Qat).
	Squash: Semifinals: Women's team: lost to Hong Kong 1-2, bagged bronze; Men's team: lost to Malaysia 1-2, clinched bronze.	60kg (1/4 final): Sumit lost to Abbaspourragani (Iri).
		Women's 62kg bronze medal match: Mansi lost to Togtokh (Mgl).

2027 ICC ODI World Cup schedule

GROUP A
India (A1), Australia (A2), Pakistan (A3), Afghanistan, Zimbabwe, Qualifier A

GROUP B
New Zealand (B1), South Africa (B2), Sri Lanka (B3), England, Bangladesh, Qualifier B

SUPER SERIES		
DATE	TEAMS	VENUE
Oct. 2	QF1 vs. QF3	Windhoek
Oct. 4	QF1 vs. QF2	Windhoek
Oct. 6	QF2 vs. QF3	Windhoek
The top two (Qualifier A and B) will make it to the group stage		
GROUP GAMES		
Oct. 7	India vs. Australia	Cape Town
Oct. 8	Pakistan vs. Afghanistan	Tshwane
Oct. 8	England vs. Bangladesh	Windhoek
Oct. 9	Zimbabwe vs. Qualifier A	Bulawayo
Oct. 9	South Africa vs. New Zealand	Cape Town
Oct. 10	India vs. Pakistan	Johannesburg
Oct. 10	Sri Lanka vs. Qualifier B	Windhoek
Oct. 11	Zimbabwe vs. Afghanistan	Bulawayo
Oct. 12	Australia vs. Qualifier A	Paarl
Oct. 12	New Zealand vs. Bangladesh	KuGompo City
Oct. 13	England vs. Sri Lanka	Windhoek
Oct. 13	South Africa vs. Qualifier B	Paarl
Oct. 14	India vs. Afghanistan	Tshwane
Oct. 15	Pakistan vs. Qualifier A	Bloemfontein
Oct. 15	Zimbabwe vs. Australia	Harare
Oct. 16	Sri Lanka vs. Bangladesh	Durban
Oct. 16	South Africa vs. England	Gqeberha
Oct. 17	India vs. Qualifier A	Bloemfontein
Oct. 17	New Zealand vs. Qualifier B	Harare
Oct. 18	Australia vs. Afghanistan	KuGompo City
Oct. 19	Zimbabwe vs. Pakistan	Harare
Oct. 19	South Africa vs. Bangladesh	Durban
Oct. 20	New Zealand vs. Sri Lanka	Johannesburg
Oct. 20	England vs. Qualifier B	Harare
Oct. 21	Afghanistan vs. Qualifier A	KuGompo City
Oct. 22	Australia vs. Pakistan	Paarl
Oct. 22	South Africa vs. Sri Lanka	Johannesburg
Oct. 23	England vs. New Zealand	Gqeberha
Oct. 23	Bangladesh vs. Qualifier B	Tshwane
Oct. 24	Zimbabwe vs. India	Victoria Falls
SUPER SEVEN		
Oct. 25	A2 vs. B3	Johannesburg
Oct. 26	B1 vs. A3	Gqeberha
Oct. 27	B2 vs. AB4*	Tshwane
Oct. 28	A1 vs. A2	Victoria Falls
Oct. 29	B1 vs. B3	KuGompo City
Oct. 30	A3 vs. AB4	Victoria Falls
Oct. 31	B2 vs. A1	Johannesburg
Nov. 1	A2 vs. B1	Victoria Falls
Nov. 2	B3 vs. AB4	Cape Town
Nov. 3	B2 vs. A3	Durban
Nov. 4	A1 vs. B1	Paarl
Nov. 5	A2 vs. AB4	Durban
Nov. 6	B2 vs. B3	Bloemfontein
Nov. 7	A1 vs. A3	Cape Town
Nov. 8	B1 vs. AB4	Durban
Nov. 9	B2 vs. A2	Gqeberha
Nov. 10	A3 vs. B3	Bloemfontein
Nov. 11	A1 vs. AB4	Gqeberha
Nov. 12	B2 vs. B1	Cape Town
Nov. 13	A2 vs. A3	Bloemfontein
Nov. 14	A1 vs. B3	Durban
* AB4 - Best fourth-placed side in Group A or B		
THE LAST FOUR		
Nov. 17	Semifinal 1	Cape Town
Nov. 18	Semifinal 2	Tshwane
THE SUMMIT CLASH		
Nov. 21	Final	Johannesburg

Captain Gill combines beauty with responsibility in pursuit of greatness

The Indian opener appears to relish the challenge of being the set batter who carries the innings through as he demonstrated in the second ODI

WI IN INDIA

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
GUWAHATI

The finest batters possess a quality which cannot quite be reduced to technique. Technique may explain the straightness of the drive, the stillness of the head, and the balance at the moment of impact. It does not explain why the whole thing should seem beautiful.

Shubman Gill has that beauty. Yet beauty, by itself, is not enough. Sport is not choreography. The beauty matters because something is at stake. On Wednesday, it was 406.

There is a particular responsibility in a big chase. Someone has to stay long enough for the number to become ordinary. Gill un-



Treat to watch: Gill was elegance personified en route his second ODI double ton. RITU RAJ KONWAR

derstands that responsibility and seems to want it. Like Virat Kohli, he appears to relish the challenge of being the set batter who

carries the innings through. Last year in England, after India lost the first Test at Leeds despite his first-innings 147, Gill responded in

the next Test by batting 549 balls for 430 across the match. Here, with the series up for grabs, he assumed that

responsibility again. He turned the chase of 406 into an exhibition of how compact and expansive can coexist, how violence may be contained within grace. His wrists worked with extraordinary delicacy. He cut late, flicked behind square, and punched through cover. He drove full-faced and straight.

Short-arm jab
When Alzarri Joseph sent down a short ball at serious pace, Gill answered with his compact short-arm jab. He used his feet repeatedly, stepping out to Roston Chase and Keemo Paul, getting to the pitch of the ball and sending it over square-leg and cow corner. Gill had no grand strategy, just a succession of modest propositions: 75-80 in the PowerPlay, no wickets; 200-210 by 25 overs; survive the new ball; ex-

ploit the older ball; remember the short side. India made 92 without loss in the first 10 overs and then exceeded Gill's next checkpoint, too. He had already spent 50 overs in the field when he began. He then batted through all 43.3 overs of the chase. There was skill, certainly, but also discipline, appetite, and fitness. The innings had the rare quality of seeming effortless while demanding everything. The numbers were spectacular: unbeaten 223 from 133 balls, his second ODI double century and India's highest successful chase. But numbers can flatten the texture of an innings. They cannot quite describe the impression of a batter who seems to have discovered that the shortest distance between himself and greatness is simply to keep batting.

Rathi helps Tamil Nadu bundle RoI out for 179

U-23 CRICKET

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Left-arm spinner Sachin Rathi's guile was too hot to handle for the Rest of India u-23 batters as Tamil Nadu u-23 bundled out the visiting team for 179 on the first day at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium on Thursday. By stumps, TN had knocked off 45 of those runs, with S.R. Athish pouncing whenever presented with an opportunity in the last hour. The foundation for the home side's dominance was laid by Rathi, whose



Rathi. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

prized scalp was Angkrish Raghuvanshi. The opening batter gave a glimpse of his talent after a cautious start, but he was undone by the tweaker as he danced down the track. Moments after raising his half-century with a boundary over deep midwicket in the 26th over, Raghuvanshi was caught short of his

crease after the ball turned away from the right-hander. Barring a 74-run third-wicket partnership between Raghuvanshi and captain Priyanshu Moliya, RoI hardly posed a threat. Rathi, who kept it tight throughout, cleaned up the middle-order and tail. "I tried to bowl in the right channels. The pitch was good for batting, so I feel my first spell changed the complexion of the game," said the spinner. **The scores:** Rest of India u-23 179 in 71.5 overs (Angkrish Raghuvanshi 51, Priyanshu Moliya 40, Varun Bhuie 41, Sachin Rathi 6/27) vs. Tamil Nadu u-23 45/0 in 11 overs.

ICC nod to use pink ball in day-time Tests on trial basis

Press Trust of India
DUBAI

The International Cricket Council (ICC) has approved the usage of pink balls in day-time Tests on a trial basis to reduce the effect of fading light in the final session of the day, which often results in the loss of overs. The new playing conditions will apply to all international series that start from this month. The ICC said the decision to use pink balls should be mutually made ahead of a Test, and it remains binding for the whole contest. A series of steps have



A Dukes pink ball. FILE PHOTO

been adopted to help the sport keep pace with the modern times. One of those is that now the play will not automatically come to an end at the fall of a wicket in the last over of the day. New limits have now been introduced, establishing three distinct size and weight specifications for men's, women's and junior cricket.

According to the new playing conditions, batters wasting time will be warned for the first and second instances, while five runs will be awarded to the fielding side if he/she repeats the offence for a third time. The regulation has also been clarified to remove ambiguity over what constitutes an overthrow. From now on, an overthrow is an attempt to direct the ball towards the stumps to prevent runs or effect a run-out. A misfield, whether an attempt to stop the ball or pass it to another fielder, will not be considered as an overthrow.

Have no issues in my body, feeling good again: Raghuvanshi

S. Shrivathsan
CHENNAI

Angkrish Raghuvanshi is back where he belongs. He is doing what he loves the most - playing cricket. The 22-year-old was deprived of that blissful feeling after being sidelined for three months with a finger injury, sustained while on Kolkata Knight Riders duty in the IPL. But Raghuvanshi is on a comeback trail and the runs are starting to flow from his willow. After hitting three half-centuries for Mumbai in the Thim-mappaiah Memorial tournament in Karnataka, he struck 51 for Rest of India u-23 on the opening day of the encounter against Tamil Nadu u-23 at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium on Thursday. "It was a pretty bad injury, and it took me months to return to cricket. But as a cricketer, you just want to be on the field and play. This is what I want to do. I always want to be on the ground rather than on a hospital bed," said Raghuvanshi. "[During my recovery], I had the hunger to get back on the field. Every day I was thinking about how I could get better. The months did not fly... I was like: 'I should be on the pitch'. I am grateful to be



Raghuvanshi. FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

playing cricket again. I have no issues in my body, and I am feeling really good about my batting. I am excited for the season, but I am not looking too far ahead," he added. **Pillar of strength**
An interaction with Raghuvanshi may be incomplete without the mention of Abhishek Nayar, his long-time mentor and head coach at KKR in IPL 2026. "He is everything to me. I have learnt a lot about life and cricket from him. Anytime I have a problem, I go to him. He is a pillar [of support] in my life. I speak to him almost every day".

SNAPSHOTS

Australia prevents a S. Africa clean sweep
POTCHEFSTROOM: Australia avoided a 3-0 clean sweep against South Africa after winning the rain-affected third and final ODI by 45 runs via DLS method on Wednesday. South Africa, which had already sealed the series with victories in Durban and Johannesburg, had reached 145 for four in 28 overs when rain stopped play. Australia had earlier posted 322 for nine after being put in. **The scores:** Australia 322/9 in 50 overs (Mitchell Marsh 56, Oliver Peake 48, Alex Carey 74, Corbin Bosch 4/60) bt South Africa 145/4 in 28 overs (Ryan Rickelton 71 n.o.). Australia won by 45 runs on DLS method; **Toss:** SA; **PoM:** Carey; **Pos:** Keshav Maharaj. **Prasidh out of third ODI**
GUWAHATI: Indian pacer Prasidh Krishna has been ruled out of the third and final ODI against the West Indies after sustaining a niggle during the second match in Guwahati on Wednesday. The final ODI will be played at New Chandigarh on Saturday. Prasidh suffered a niggle and could bowl only five overs and returned figures of one for 45 in the second one-dayer. Meanwhile, Washington Sundar has been withdrawn from India's squad for the T20I series against the West Indies starting on October 6. Naman Dhir has been named as his replacement.



Fine knock: Carey made 74 off 88 balls to help Australia set up a defendable total. AFP

The decision was taken in view of the upcoming Test series against New Zealand. With the Ranji Trophy season commencing on October 11, Washington will get an opportunity to play red-ball cricket for Tamil Nadu and prepare for the Test series. **Niki, Vaishnavi spin India-A to big win in one-off 'Test'**
MOHALI: Spinners Niki Prasad and Vaishnavi Sharma helped India-A hammer Australia-A by 281 runs in the one-off 'Test' at Mohali on Thursday. Chasing a mammoth 446, the visiting side was bundled out for 164 on the third day. Niki claimed five for 50 while Vaishnavi scalped three for 58. **The scores:** India-A 364 & 257 in 64.2 overs (Priya Puniya 59, Yastika Bhatia 46, Anushka Sharma 46, Lilly Mills 5/88, Frankie Nicklin 4/67) bt Australia-A 176 & 164 in 76 overs (Tess Flintoff 58, Vaishnavi Sharma 3/58, Niki Prasad 5/50). **PoM:** Niki.

Miffed Ronaldo leaves Portugal camp
COPENHAGEN: Portugal captain Cristiano Ronaldo announced on Wednesday that he had left the team's training camp in Denmark following a press conference by coach Jorge Jesus. The veteran coach had said that Ronaldo, who spent the entire match on the bench against Norway on Sunday, would also not start the Nations League clash away to Denmark either. **LIVE TELECAST**
Irani Cup: day 2, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.
India-A vs Australia-A: Second 'Test' day 4, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.
Football: Nations League, Sony Sports Ten 2, 5 & LIV, 7.30, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Saturday)
Crickets: Asian Games (Men), Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Saturday)
Asian Games: Sony Sports Ten 2, 5 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Saturday)

Chennai Open to be moved to Manila next year

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

The WTA 250 Chennai Open, the country's only top-tier tennis tournament, will be held from November 2 to 8 at the SDAT Stadium in Nungambakkam. However, next year, in the same slot, it will be replaced with a first-ever tour-level event in the Philippines as various stakeholders look to capitalise on the rapidly growing fanbase of the 21-year-old Alexandra Eala, currently ranked 18th in the world. Along with the return of a WTA 125 event, held for the first time in the Philippines in January this season, a WTA 250 tournament will make its debut in Manila in late 2027 and is scheduled from November 1 to 7. Chennai played host to a WTA 250 tournament for the first time in 2022. The event was held last year in the city for the second time after being relocated from Mexico. "That (Eala's rise) is a factor. To have a WTA footprint in the Philippines, that's definitely an important contributing factor," Alastair Garland, managing director of the tennis division of Octagon, the sports agency that holds the license for the event, told *The Hindu*.

Brazil football team arrives in Kolkata



Gearing up: The Indian football team trains ahead of Saturday's friendly against Brazil. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

Members of the Brazil football team touched down at the Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose International Airport here on Thursday in a chartered flight for the friendly against India. The arrival sets the stage for the FIFA international friendly, where the Indian men's national team will take on the might of the Selecao, at the Salt Lake Stadium on Saturday. The creativity, flair and skill of Brazil's 'Jogo Bonito' have long made the Selecao an enduring icon among football-lovers in Bengal and across India. Their presence in Kolkata adds a special emotional dimension to the eagerly-awaited fixture. The biggest attraction among the visitors is Vini-

cius Junior. The Real Madrid forward has emerged as one of the leading stars of the modern game, renowned for his pace and dribbling ability. Vinicius Junior missed his previous chance to visit India when he was ruled out of the 2017 FIFA U-17 World Cup, hosted by India. Flamengo held him back after their Copa do Brasil final defeat, despite the then 17-year-old having already secured a €45 million move to Real Madrid. It is a full-circle moment for Vinicius, who has finally landed in India and finds himself to be the biggest attraction as Carlo Ancelotti's Brazil prepares to face the Blue Tigers. With Raphinha withdrawing due to injury, the Vinicius factor is only expected to heighten the excitement and galvanise support in Kolkata.

New car regulations favouring aggressive drivers: Albon

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI



Albon. AP

Atlassian Williams driver Alexander Albon feels the new car regulations suit drivers with a more aggressive driving style. Speaking ahead of the Bahrain GP, to be held in Sepang, Malaysia, this weekend, Albon reckoned it is one reason championship leader Andrea Kimi Antonelli has excelled so far, despite it being just his second year in the sport. "The cars themselves are a lot smaller. Basically, I think a lot of the drivers push entries, so if you think famously, someone like Lewis (Hamilton) and I think Kimi does a very similar thing. They are being rewarded because the rear tyres are not as strong this year as they were in previous years, relative to the front tyres," explained Albon. The other main challenge has been battery deployment, and Albon revealed it has taken time for him to adapt. "A lot of the deployment is down to the drivers, the way the driver downshifts and upshifts, also the way the driver brakes. The biggest factor is how the driver

uses the throttle. At first, when it was changed, it was very difficult to understand. It was very against my personal driving style. And so, over time - we are in October now - I have only just started to feel natural driving a car, which is a lot longer than it takes," added the Thai-British driver. Williams, which finished fifth in 2025, has struggled so far, sitting ninth in the standings, and Albon said the team is focused on next year. "All the simulator work that we're doing behind the scenes is now focused on next year. And generally, the language which the whole team speaks is more about next year's car. So sometimes you need to take one step back in many ways or hold some of the development back to make sure that you make a bigger step later on," said Albon.

Nishikori calls time on his career

Agence France-Presse
TOKYO



Kei Nishikori AP

Japan's Kei Nishikori, Asia's most decorated men's tennis player, brought the curtain down on his pioneering career on Thursday, after losing to Frances Tiafoe on home turf. The 36-year-old, who announced his retirement in May, was the first Japanese player to reach a Grand Slam final, losing the 2014 US Open to Croatia's Marin Cilic. He was the first Japanese man to make the top

10 in the ATP world rankings and won 12 titles on tour, including two victories in Tokyo. Nishikori also won bronze in the men's singles at the 2016 Rio Olympics.

